

PRATT - MS in Information Experience Design

Requirements

A statement of purpose (**no more than 500 words**) describing long-range goals and interest in the chosen discipline and reason for applying to the program. The Admissions Committee views the statement of purpose as a means of gauging an applicant's fit in the program, how intellectually curious they are about the world around them, and how they'd contribute to the diversity of the student population at the School of Information. The statement is also a way for the Committee to learn more about an applicant beyond what is indicated on a resume or transcript. Please tell us why you believe the program is right for you and how/why it aligns with your long-term goals and professional aspirations. Please do not include details that can be found in your resume.

SOP

Growing up in Bangalore, life unfolded in straight lines and stark edges, where every structure was a servant of purpose, and aesthetics took a backseat to utility. It wasn't until I wandered through the vibrant streets of Barcelona, for a trip during high school, that I discovered the quiet poetry of aesthetics in public spaces. This revelation stirred a deep admiration within me during those early years. My undergraduate studies in Industrial Design and diverse professional experiences have shaped my ensuing creative practice. During this time, I have explored the design process in areas like innovative product development, user-centric methodologies, and systems thinking. This ability to use scientific advancements to create new products and services that drive business and economy while making people's lives easier and more comfortable excites and motivates me to build a long-term career in this field. I now wish to augment my portfolio and train my design thinking mindset to scope, refine, and deliver practicable solutions and translate abstract ideas, theories, and plans into practice through an MS in Information Experience Design.

This academic goal is a well-thought-out progression of my interests and skillset. I have always loved arts and crafts as a young boy and knew that I wanted to work in a field that would allow me to express my creativity and challenge me intellectually. My Bachelor's degree from India's premier design school National Institute of Design (NID), has given my design thought, creativity, and critical thinking a decisively humane and people-oriented direction. It introduced me to three facets of design: systems design, service design, and interaction design – each with its unique applications that called for deeper exploration. The systems approach calls for looking at a problem area holistically before identifying an intervention type, service design relies on solving design problems with the aid of techno-digital interventions, whereas interaction designs shed light on making such designs more user-centric.

From developing a mechanical tool for garland weaving that improved the efficiency and comfort of flower vendors to creating an educational activity kit exploring self-identity for children, (the latter is selected for presentation and publication at the International Conference on Research into Design - ICoRD'25), all my projects have reiterated the interconnection of design, community, and sustainability.

Collectively, these five years of formative learning have coalesced into my chosen career path in Information Experience Design. After graduate studies, I plan to work as a UX Researcher or Innovation Strategist with creative firms like Google, Hinge Inc., or Siemens Healthcare, on projects that blend strategy, design, and technology. Specifically, I aim to work on service ecosystems that address pressing socio-economic inequities by co-creating accessible services for marginalized communities - such as affordable healthcare frameworks or skill-building digital platforms for rural artisans, inspired by my earlier work in Assam. I am also open to working on digital products like fintech solutions, or interactive educational platforms. My long-term vision is to become an expert in human-centric design by creating versatile design solutions that have high utility, speak to the audience, and help achieve the underlying business objectives.

The **Information Experience Design** program at Pratt Institute is the perfect conduit to materialize these. I am particularly interested in the Practical Ethnography for User Experience, Speculative Design, and Information Architecture modules which encourage design thinking and conversance with industry-relevant tools. Pratt's emphasis on practical learning through industry collaborations, and live projects, and its state-of-the-art UX labs like the semantic lab and observation room provide an ideal environment for me to experiment with emerging technologies such as Usability Machines. I am excited to collaborate with the intellectually spirited student cohort for international study opportunities and engage in team-based innovation to devise solutions for contemporary social and environmental challenges. By making full use of these and the numerous other opportunities on campus, I do not doubt that I will become an industry-ready professional, possessing the skills I need to achieve my goals.

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Growing up in Bangalore, life unfolded in straight lines and stark edges, where every structure was a servant of purpose, and aesthetics took a backseat to utility. It wasn't until I wandered through the vibrant streets of Barcelona, on a trip during high school, that I discovered the quiet poetry of aesthetics in public spaces.

As I took on co-curricular design assignments during undergraduate studies, I discovered art also had the power to effect social change. What reinforced this was my on-site graduation project in collaboration with Grant Thornton, where I worked with the indigenous bamboo artisans from Assam to revive the endangered practice of crafting a Japi. Immersing myself in the local culture deepened my understanding of community-driven design and its impact on artisans and customers alike. From redesigning construction barricades, creating an educational activity kit to teach children about personal boundaries, to developing a mechanical tool for flower vendors, my Bachelor's in Industrial Design has reiterated the interconnection of design and community. This understanding has been further strengthened through my work at Thinkonomers (HDL), where I learned to apply user feedback in the design process; Pichkaari Design Studio, where I worked on rebranding projects and developed user flow enhancement prototypes; Grant Thornton; and finally, in my current role as a UX/UI designer at BRND Studio, where I handle end-to-end design for SaaS dashboards, educational platforms, and teaching tools. These experiences have amalgamated into my own design philosophy, based on creating superlative experiences for both virtual and real spaces, and coalesced into my chosen career path in Service Design.

After graduate studies, I plan to work as a UX Researcher or Innovation Strategist with creative firms like Google, or Huge Inc., on projects that blend strategy, design, and technology. My long-term vision is to become an expert in human-centric design by creating versatile design solutions that have high utility, speak to the audience, and help achieve the underlying business objectives. Inspired by my Japi Art project, I aim to work on service ecosystems that address socio-economic inequities by co-creating accessible services like affordable healthcare frameworks or skill-building digital platforms for marginalized communities and rural artisans.

The MS Information Experience Design program at Pratt is the perfect conduit for this. I am particularly interested in the Practical Ethnography for User Experience, Speculative Design, and Information Architecture, which encourage design thinking and conversance with industry-relevant tools. Pratt's emphasis on experiential learning through industry collaborations, live projects, and its state-of-the-art Semantic Lab and Observation Room provide an ideal environment for me to try my hand at emerging technologies like Usability Machines. I am excited to collaborate with the intellectually spirited student cohort for the Pratt Design Challenge and engage in team-based innovation to devise solutions for contemporary social and environmental challenges. By making full use of these and the numerous other opportunities on campus, I have no doubt that I will become an industry-ready professional, possessing the skills I need to achieve my goals.

RCA - MA Service Design

Requirements

Please provide a 300-word written personal statement that addresses the following points:

1. Introduce yourself, your interests, and your motivations for applying to the Royal College of Art, and to this program in particular.
2. Briefly summarise any educational background and professional experience to date that will support your application.
3. Tell us what you want to do in the future.

From redesigning construction barricades, creating an educational activity kit to teach children about personal boundaries, developing a mechanical tool for flower vendors, to promoting a dying indigenous, bamboo art form from Assam, my Bachelor's in Industrial Design showed me that art is not just for aesthetic but also has the power to effect social change. This understanding has been further strengthened through my work at Thinkonomers (HDL), and Pichkaari Design Studio, my current role as a UX/UI designer at BRND Studio, where I handle end-to-end design for SaaS dashboards, educational platforms, and teaching tools.

This dual exposure to traditional rebranding as well as tech-intensive design processes and tools has amalgamated into my own design philosophy based on creating superlative experiences for both virtual and real spaces, and coalesced into my chosen career path in Service Design.

After graduate studies, I plan to work as a UX Researcher or Innovation Strategist with creative firms like the Ford Human Centred Design Lab, on projects that blend strategy, design, and technology. My long-term vision is to become an expert in human-centric design by creating versatile design solutions that have high utility, speak to the audience, and help achieve the underlying business objectives.

The MA Service Design program at RCA is the perfect conduit for this. I am particularly interested in the Service Design Practice module, which encourage design thinking and conversance with industry-relevant tools. I am excited to collaborate with the intellectually spirited student cohort for the Grand Challenge and AcrossRCA and engage in team-based innovation to devise solutions for contemporary social and environmental challenges.

With RCA's emphasis on experiential learning its state-of-the-art Helen Hamlyn Centre for Design and Terra Carta Design Lab, I have no doubt that I will become an industry-ready professional, possessing the skills I need to achieve my goals.

Why do you want to attend SCAD? * (250 words max)

Through my undergraduate study of Industrial Design, and field experience, I have explored the design process in areas like innovative product development, user-centric methodologies, and systems thinking. This ability to use scientific advancements to create new products and services that drive business and economy and at the same time make people's lives easier and more comfortable is something that excites and motivates me to build a long-term career in this field. The MA in Service Design from SCAD will sharpen my design thinking mindset to refine and deliver practicable solutions and translate abstract ideas, theories and plans into practice.

I am particularly interested in the Mixed Methods Research, Visualizing Services, and Systemic Innovation for Service Evolution modules which encourage design thinking and conversance with industry relevant tools. SCAD's emphasis on practical learning through industry collaborations, live projects, and its state-of-the-art Gulfstream Center, model shop, and Computer labs provide an ideal environment for me to experiment with emerging technologies such as AR/VR and Immersive media. I am also excited at the prospect of collaborating with the intellectually spirited student cohort for the SCAD Challenge and engage in team-based innovation for SCAD SERVE and its Design for Good courses where students work pro-bono for NPOs to devise solutions for contemporary social and environmental challenges.

By making full use of these and the numerous other opportunities on campus, I have no doubt that I will become an industry-ready professional, possessing the skills I need to achieve my goals.

Who is your favorite artist/designer and why? 250 word max

Amongst pioneers of human-centered service design, Steve Krug's seminal work, *Don't Make Me Think*, has profoundly shaped my understanding of design. His philosophy is radical in its simplicity: he emphasizes usability principles such as clear hierarchies and intuitive pathways. In other words, good service design ensures that interactions—both digital and physical—are as effortless as possible.

But like all novice designers, I too initially focused on surface-level requirements and aesthetic designs. Over time, through practice and feedback (and some humbling mistakes!), I realized the importance of going to the root of user needs, reducing fluff and making designs that work so well that they become almost invisible to the user.

I was fortunate to find a mentor who shares these values—Mr. Sudhir Bhatia, the founder of BRND, my current studio. He often says that a well-designed system is like a well-oiled machine; it may not always be aesthetically beautiful, but it operates smoothly, ensuring that every interaction contributes to a cohesive and effective experience. Working with him has reinforced my belief that service design is not just about optimizing interfaces but orchestrating entire systems to serve people better.

While I do not have an absolute favorite, Krug's teachings and Bhatia's mentorship have made a significant impact on my design ethos. By studying their work and integrating their techniques into my

design process, I hope to create functional products and services that reduce cognitive load, and ultimately enhance the lives of those who interact with them.

How will your life and/or professional experience impact your ability to succeed at SCAD? 250 word max

During the past five years of immersion in the field of design, I have developed a strong foundation in user-centered research, participatory design, behavioral mapping, and service innovation. From redesigning construction barricades, creating an educational activity kit to teach children about personal boundaries, developing a mechanical tool for flower vendors, to promoting a dying indigenous, bamboo art form from Assam, my academic research has given me an acute EQ approach to empathize with diverse user groups and develop practical, impactful solutions for sensitive and high-impact domains—an essential skill for tackling real-world service challenges I will encounter in the practicum-based teaching-learning environment of SCAD.

On the technical skills front, I have experience in behavioral mapping and iterative prototyping. Moreover, my UX/UI design experience, my work at Thinkonomers (HDL), Pichkaari Design Studio, and BRND Studio has given me a trans-disciplinary and versatile skillset, enabling me to effectively navigate my graduate coursework in service blueprinting and systems thinking.

My dual exposure to traditional rebranding as well as tech-intensive design processes and tools has amalgamated into my own design philosophy based on creating superlative experiences for both virtual and real spaces. Personally, leading multi-industry and multicultural projects has made me comfortable with ambiguity and iterative problem-solving, both of which are at the crux of service design. Lastly, I believe my passion for accessibility and inclusion also mirror SCAD's own values and ethos of diversity and will enable me to contribute meaningfully to its collaborative studio projects.

Do you feel your grades and/or test scores accurately reflect your potential to succeed at SCAD? If not, why? 250 word max

Throughout my academic journey, I have maintained a consistently rising scorecard and earned the Highest Scorer award in my graduating cohort. But while my GPA of ____ in my Bachelor's in Industrial Design provides a glimpse into my academic progress, I believe the essence of design, goes beyond conventional grading metrics and is demonstrated through practical application and impact. Through projects such as redesigning safety infrastructure, developing community-driven service solutions, and enhancing user experience in digital platforms I have learned how to bridge the gap between design theory and real-world implementation. Being a proactive learner, I have amplified my classroom study through specialized certificates in Web Design and GenAI. To share my passion for design I have also worked as a mentor for my juniors at NID, facilitating lectures and training workshops on advanced design research methodologies.

I believe my success as a service designer stems from my result-oriented mindset and iterative approach to design. My professional trajectory, across both traditional and digital media and design

sectors, demonstrate my ability to integrate strategic thinking with creative execution. These skills extend beyond academic grades, reflecting my ability to approach challenges with curiosity, adaptability, and crafting holistic solutions that are functional, user-centric, and sustainable.

In essence, my academic performance, hands-on experience in service and interaction design, and my self-driven attitude towards learning assure me that I have the skills, discipline, and mindset to succeed at SCAD. I am eager to refine my expertise and contribute meaningfully to its dynamic design community.

Statement of Purpose? 500-750 word max

Your statement should give an overview of your academic and personal experience, describing preparation for and commitment to further study at SCAD, as well as educational and professional aspirations.

Growing up in Bangalore, life unfolded in straight lines and stark edges, where every structure was a servant of purpose, and aesthetics took a backseat to utility. It wasn't until I wandered through the vibrant streets of Barcelona, for a trip during high school, that I discovered the quiet poetry of aesthetics in public spaces. This revelation stirred a deep admiration within me during those early years. My ensuing creative practice has been shaped by my undergraduate studies in Industrial Design and diverse professional experiences.

As I took on curricular assignments to apply classroom theories in realtime practice, I gradually identified my design niche. For my graduation assignment with Grant Thornton, I worked with indigenous bamboo artisans from Assam to revive endangered Japi crafts and saw firsthand how design had the unique power to effect social change. For a similar project, by using a participatory design approach, I designed a mechanical tool that alleviated the physical strain and increased the productivity of flower vendors engaged in garland weaving activities. I also used behavioral mapping to understand the challenges faced by pedestrians and drivers, designed a lightweight, highly visible construction barricade to improve safety for pedestrians during peak traffic hours.

Beyond these community-based projects, I worked on two tech-intensive projects. In the first, I analyzed STI management practices and barriers restricting access to services among female sex workers (FSWs) in Bhopal. Employing snowball sampling techniques to locate their work zones and, using methods like GIGA mapping user journeys, I developed a Trigger and Response Model to better interpret the data. The project led to recommendations for community-centric support systems such as mobile clinics and awareness programs. In the second project I created an educational activity kit to help children explore self-identity. By utilizing user journey mapping, participatory testing, and iterative prototyping, I built a tool to help children understand and express their feelings, which was later presented and published at the International Conference on Research into Design (ICoRD'25).

From a bird's eye perspective, all my projects have reiterated the interconnection of design, utility, and sustainability. This understanding has been further strengthened through my professional experiences - at Thinkonomers (HDL) where I learned about the importance of user feedback in the design process, Pichkaari Design Studio, where I worked on rebranding projects and developed user flow enhancement prototypes, Grant Thornton, and finally in my current role as a UX/UI designer at

BRND Studio, where I handle end-to-end design for SaaS dashboards, educational platforms, and teaching tools. These experiences have ingrained in me that user experience should be the top priority in the design process and helped shape my own design philosophy, which is based on creating superlative, easy to use experiences for modern spaces, both virtual and real. For example, in my initial projects, I dove headfirst into design but with experience and trial and error, I realised that logic in design will hold little value unless it is thoughtfully integrated with an intuitive understanding of how it will be used by humans.

Collectively, these five years of formative learnings have coalesced into my chosen career path in Service Design. After graduate studies, I plan to work as a Service Designer or Innovation Strategist with creative firms like Adobe or Deloitte, on projects that blend strategy, design, and technology. I am passionate about working on service ecosystems that address critical challenges in accessibility, equity, and inclusion for underserved populations. For example, I want to design services for marginalized communities, such as affordable healthcare frameworks or digital platforms for skilling and business training for rural and tribal artisans. These goals are inspired by my earlier project in Assam, where I worked with artisans to develop community-driven solutions. Additionally, I am open to contributing to digital products like fintech solutions or interactive educational platforms, using my design background to create user-friendly, impactful tools. My long-term vision is to become an expert in human-centric design by creating versatile design solutions that have high utility, speak to the audience, and help achieve the underlying business objectives.

I have come to appreciate that product design albeit a creative process, requires conversance with software design tools, user-centric methodologies, and an allied understanding of socio-economic dynamics and business management to truly understand the consumer ask. While I have been working on developing the aforementioned proficiencies, I require advanced training and international exposure to the field which I hope to gain through the MA Service Design at SCAD.

SVA - Statement of Purpose

1. Personal written statement: We want to know how critical and creative thinking shapes your design work and other pursuits. Please answer the following questions in 500-700 words:

- 1. Tell us about someone you look up to and why. The person can be a designer, a friend, a relative, someone in your neighborhood—anyone who inspires you and your creative practice.**
- 2. Imagine it is 20 years from the present moment. Describe your life—what kind of work are you engaging in, what are your home and community like, in what ways have you shaped the field of interaction design, and how has the field of interaction design shaped your life?**
- 3. MFA Interaction Design offers modest, merit-based scholarships. Please indicate in your essay if you would like to be considered for a merit-based departmental award.**

Please submit this as a PDF document.

750 words maximum.

Q1. Tell us about someone you look up to and why. The person can be a designer, a friend, a relative, someone in your neighborhood—anyone who inspires you and your creative practice.

Q2. Imagine it is 20 years from the present moment. Describe your life—what kind of work are you engaging in, what are your home and community like, in what ways have you shaped the field of interaction design, and how has the field of interaction design shaped your life?

Q3. MFA Interaction Design offers modest, merit-based scholarships. Please indicate in your essay if you would like to be considered for a merit-based departmental award.

Amongst stalwarts of user-centered design, the person who inspires me most is Steve Krug. His seminal work *Don't Make Me Think*, a book on web usability, has profoundly shaped my understanding of design. Krug is a radical in a way, emphasizing function over aesthetics, advocating for self-evident designs that prioritize user experience above all else. What I read this as, is that, good design should simplify, not complicate. Krug does this by focusing on clear visual hierarchies and ensuring navigation serves its purpose. I have adapted this idea to my own work believing that a product's experience holds more value and precedence over visual interface. Like all novice designers, I too initially focused on surface-level requirements, jumping straight into creating the best aesthetic designs I could. But over time, through practice and feedback (and some humbling mistakes!), I realized the importance of going to the root of user needs, reducing fluff and making designs that embody clarity—an approach Krug champions.

I was searching for like-minded professionals who shared this philosophy and have been fortunate to work with Mr. Sudhir Bhatia, **the founder of _____** - my current studio. His emphasis on experience-driven design has reiterated that a design is like a well-oiled machine, although at times unpleasant to the eye from the outside, it works smooth as butter on the inside, fulfilling its intrinsic purpose. Working with him has allowed me to stay true to these principles, reaffirming that thoughtful, user-centered design is at the heart of innovation.

While I do not have an absolute favorite, Krug's teachings and Bhatia's mentorship has made a significant impact on my personal values and design ethos. By studying their work and integrating their techniques into my design process, I hope to create functional and intuitive products and services.

I envision future Designer Rachit, working on ideas that blend strategy, design, and technology, becoming an expert in human-centric design by creating versatile design solutions that have high utility, speak to the audience, and help achieve the underlying business objectives. My collaboration with bamboo artisans in Assam, to help promote the endangered Japi craft, has shown me how design can breathe new life into traditional art forms. In the future, I see myself creating modular, self-sustaining products and services like furniture with IoT sensors to monitor air quality or crosswalks that adjust automatically to ensure the safety of pedestrians during peak hours. Although this may sound utopian, with the right mix of practicality and technology, it can become a blueprint for a better future.

In preparation for such a lofty career progression, I have earned a bachelor's degree from India's premier design school National Institute of Design (NID). I have worked on innovative projects like redesigning construction barricades, creating an educational activity kit to teach children about personal boundaries, developing a mechanical tool for flower vendors, to promoting a dying indigenous, bamboo art form from Assam. I have also challenged myself by undertaking industry internships to learn the real-world applicability of my studies. At Thinkonomers (HDL), I learned to apply user feedback in the design process; my work with Pichkaari Design Studio, revolved around rebranding projects and developing user flow enhancement prototypes; at Grant Thornton, I undertook a community-driven design project to revive endangered Japi craft of Assam; and finally, in my current role as a UX/UI designer at BRND Studio, I handle end-to-end design for SaaS dashboards, educational platforms, and teaching tools.

In addition to my academic and professional pursuits, I have actively participated in various extracurricular activities that have refined my teamwork and leadership and given me a well-rounded skillset that I believe will enable me to perform at my best during my Masters.

It has been an incredible journey these past few years and I am now excited to savor every experience of graduate life, whether it is the rigorous course curriculum, access to the SVA alumni network, or the prospect of living in NYC. As an independent individual, I would appreciate your feedback on my candidacy and kindly request you to consider any merit-based

scholarship that may be available. would not only ease my financial situation but also allow me to fully devote myself to my studies and actively contribute to the university community. I bring with me a diverse set of experiences, skills, and perspectives that I believe would greatly enrich the SVA's student body. I am deeply passionate about learning, committed to academic excellence, and eager to make a positive impact both inside and outside the classroom.

SVA - Video Script

Personal video introduction: We want to know who you are and why you are choosing to apply to the MFA ixD program. We invited you to share your unique personality with us in your video. Record a video introduction answering the following:

- **What excites you about the field of interaction design at this moment in your life?**
- **What does interaction design mean to you?**
- **We invite you to share your unique personality with us in your video.**
- **video must be submitted as a URL**
- **90 seconds maximum**
- **Please add the URL of the video to your written statement.**

I'm Rachit Singhi, an industrial designer with a passion for creating thoughtful, impactful design experiences and solutions.

Growing up in Bangalore, I was surrounded by residential and corporate complexes with more focus on utility than aesthetics. Conversely, when I visited heritage places in India or Europe, I saw there was also a strong element of visuals to each structure. As I undertook design assignments during undergraduate studies, I discovered art also had the power to effect social change - whether it's creating tools to support underserved communities or designing products that improve daily experiences. One project that deeply shaped my perspective was my work with indigenous bamboo artisans from Assam to revive the endangered Japi craft. This experience reinforced my belief that that design doesn't just change environments—it has the power to effect social change. But this process requires deep research and analysis of the user's ecosystem, along with careful attention to where the most impactful changes can happen.

This has seeded my own design philosophy - for me, interaction design is not just about aesthetics or functionality—it's about weaving empathy, creativity, and systemic thinking into my solutions. I believe good design should empower users while addressing larger societal needs. With technology and design evolving at breakneck speed, ensuring accessibility to diverse populations is more important than ever. I'm thus excited to bring my passion for impactful, user-centered solutions and my drive for interdisciplinary innovation to the next chapter of my journey—and I can't wait to share that with you at SVA!

Rachit Singhi – CSE – UAL – MA Service Design

Personal statement advice

Your personal statement should be maximum 500 words and include: your reasons for choosing the course your current creative practice and how this course will help you achieve your future plans, any relevant education and experience, especially if you do not have any formal academic qualifications. Visit our personal statement page for more advice.

Growing up in Bangalore, life unfolded in straight lines and stark edges, where every structure was a servant of purpose, and aesthetics took a backseat to utility. It wasn't until I wandered through the vibrant streets of Rajasthan, on a trip during high school, that I discovered the quiet poetry of aesthetics in public spaces. This revelation stirred a deep admiration within me during those early years and led me to pursue a degree in design for my undergraduate education.

As I took on design assignments in college, I increasingly saw that it also had the unique power to effect social change. What reinforced this was my on-site graduation project in collaboration with Grant Thornton, where I worked with the indigenous bamboo artisans from Assam to revive the endangered practice of crafting a Japi. Immersing myself in the local culture deepened my understanding of community-driven design and the impact it can have on the artisan as well as the customer. From redesigning construction barricades, creating an educational activity kit that educates children about personal boundaries, to developing a mechanical tool for flower vendors, my undergraduate studies in Industrial Design have reiterated the interconnection of design and community. This understanding has been further strengthened through my professional experiences at Thinkonomers (HDL), where I learned about the importance of user feedback in the design process; Pichkaari Design Studio, where I worked on rebranding projects and developed user flow enhancement prototypes; Grant Thornton; and finally, in my current role as a UX/UI designer at BRND Studio, where I handle end-to-end design for SaaS dashboards, educational platforms, and teaching tools. These experiences have helped shape my own design philosophy, which is based on creating superlative experiences for modern spaces, both virtual and real.

This has coalesced into my chosen career path in Service Design. After graduate studies, I plan to work as a Service Designer or Innovation Strategist with creative firms like IDEO, Fjord, or Deloitte Digital, on projects that blend strategy, design, and technology. My long-term vision is to become an expert in human-centric design by creating versatile design solutions that have high utility, speak to the audience, and help achieve the underlying business objectives.

The MA Service Design program at UAL is the perfect conduit to materialize these. I am particularly interested in the Design Futures and Collaborative Unit modules, which encourage design thinking and conversance with industry-relevant tools. UAL's emphasis on practical learning through industry collaborations, live projects, and its state-of-the-art Service Futures Lab, Creative Technology Lab, and Digital Space provide an ideal environment for me to experiment with emerging technologies such as VR and machine learning. I am excited to collaborate with the intellectually spirited student cohort for the UAL Creative Hackathon and engage in team-based innovation to devise solutions for contemporary social and environmental challenges. By making full use of these and the numerous other opportunities on campus, I have no doubt that I will become an industry-ready professional, possessing the skills I need to achieve my goals.

Video task advice

We would like you to submit a 2-3 minute video to help us learn more about you. When recording your task, please face the camera and speak in English.

What to include in your video task

- Choose 1 project from your portfolio and explain how it challenged you and your understanding of service design.
- Tell us how this experience inspired you to apply for the MA in Service Design at the London College of Communication.

Script:

I am Rachit Singhi, a user-centered industrial designer passionate about creating thoughtful, impactful design experiences and solutions. With the same motive in mind, I undertook a project as a summer trainee with Grant Thornton Bharat. This corporation provides services to business sectors, such as accounting and auditing.

One such service the organization works on involves collaborating with multiple rural sector stakeholders as part of its corporate social responsibility program. I had the opportunity to work at the organization as a designer for my graduation project, where I collaborated with the bamboo artisans of Assam (an economically backward state in India) for six months, understanding their craft techniques and developing two product ranges that appealed to the current market, thereby increasing the income levels of the artisans. However, the program had several loopholes that I discovered within the first month.

Considering I wasn't the first to conduct such training with the artisans, it raised an important question: Why had previous training sessions not been effective? This question opened a can of worms, allowing me to examine the entire project holistically. I began questioning whether simply having an output that the organization thinks is impactful was enough or if it was far more important to consider how to deliver the output to maximize its impact, considering what the key stakeholders are looking for from such interventions and training.

This project became a lens through which I understood the importance of service design. It highlighted the importance of not coming up with a solution for the identified problem area until proper research has been undertaken with the primary players involved in the ecosystem. Instead of taking a top-down approach of training deployment, I took a bottom-up approach of doing training needs assessment and customized the training delivery by getting more native (dialect) speakers on board. This project highlighted the idea that just having a particular solution isn't sufficient; rather, how the intervention is delivered can make all the difference in achieving a meaningful impact that sticks and is applied in a real-world scenario.

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This project became a lens through which I understood the importance of service design. It highlighted the importance of not coming up with a solution for the identified problem area until proper research has been undertaken with the primary players involved in the ecosystem. Instead of taking a top-down approach of training deployment, I took a bottom-up approach of doing training needs assessment and customized the training delivery by getting more native (dialect) speakers on board. This project highlighted the idea that just having a particular solution isn't sufficient; rather, how the intervention is delivered can make all the difference in achieving a meaningful impact that sticks and is applied in a real-world scenario.

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University of Washington - Personal Statement 01

How have your prior activities and experiences (e.g., things you have done at school, in the workplace, in your community, and/or extracurricular activities) prepared you for this program and this field? Please provide specific examples. [600 words maximum]

Growing up in Bangalore, life unfolded in straight lines and stark edges, where every structure was a servant of purpose, and aesthetics took a backseat to utility. It wasn't until I wandered through the vibrant streets of Barcelona, for a trip during high school, that I discovered the quiet poetry of aesthetics in public spaces. This revelation stirred a deep admiration within me during those early years. My ensuing creative practice has been shaped by my undergraduate studies in Industrial Design and diverse professional experiences. In this time, I have explored the design process in areas like innovative product development, user-centric methodologies, and systems thinking. This ability to use scientific advancements to create new products and services that drive business and economy and at the same time make people's lives easier and more comfortable is something that excites and motivates me to build a long-term career in this field.

I pursued my Bachelor's degree from India's premier design school, the National Institute of Design (NID), where my design thinking and creativity took a decisively humane and people-oriented direction. During my time at NID, I was introduced to three facets of design: systems design, service design, and interaction design. The systems approach taught me to look at a problem area in its entirety before identifying potential interventions, while service design focused on solving problems through technological interventions. But interaction design appealed to me the most due to its user-centricity and accessible designs.

In college, I took on multiple design assignments that further helped me identify my design niche. For my graduation assignment with Grant Thornton, I worked with indigenous bamboo artisans from Assam to revive endangered Japi crafts and saw firsthand how design had the unique power to effect social change. For a similar project, by using a participatory design approach, I designed a mechanical tool that alleviated the physical strain and increased the productivity of flower vendors engaged in garland weaving activities. I also used behavioral mapping to understand the challenges faced by pedestrians and drivers, designed a lightweight, highly visible construction barricade to improve safety for pedestrians during peak traffic hours.

Beyond these community-based projects, I worked on two tech-intensive projects. In the first, I analyzed STI management practices and barriers restricting access to services among female sex workers (FSWs) in Bhopal. Employing snowball sampling techniques to locate their work zones and, using methods like GIGA mapping user journeys, I developed a Trigger and Response Model to better interpret the data. The project led to recommendations for

community-centric support systems such as mobile clinics and awareness programs. In the second project I created an educational activity kit to help children explore self-identity. By utilizing user journey mapping, participatory testing, and iterative prototyping, I built a tool to help children understand and express their feelings, which was later presented and published at the International Conference on Research into Design (ICoRD'25).

My myriad set of formative learnings has coalesced into my passion for making a career in human-centered design and user experience research. I have come to appreciate that product design albeit a creative process, requires conversance with software design tools, user-centric methodologies, and an allied understanding of socio-economic dynamics and business management to truly understand the consumer ask. While I have been working on developing the aforementioned proficiencies, I require advanced training and international exposure to the field which I hope to gain through the MS Human Centered Design & Engineering at University of Washington.

University of Washington - Personal Statement 02

Please describe your particular interest in Human Centered Design & Engineering, and explain what specific elements of the program make it a good fit for you. How will this program assist you in your longer-term goals? Please provide specific examples. [600 words maximum]

I have explored the design process in areas like innovative product development, user-centric methodologies, and systems thinking. This ability to use scientific advancements to create new products and services that drive business and economy and at the same time make people's lives easier and more comfortable is something that excites and motivates me to build a long-term career in this field. I now wish to augment my portfolio and train my design thinking mindset to scope, refine and deliver practicable solutions and translate abstract ideas, theories and plans into practice through an MS in Human Centered Design & Engineering (HCDE).

After completing my graduate studies, I aim to work as a User Experience (UX) Researcher or Innovation Strategist with creative firms such as Accenture, Publicis Sapient or Google. I am passionate about working on service ecosystems that address critical challenges in accessibility, equity, and inclusion for underserved populations. For example, I want to design services for marginalized communities, such as affordable healthcare frameworks or digital platforms for skilling and business training for rural and tribal artisans. These goals are inspired by my earlier project in Assam, where I worked with artisans to develop community-

driven solutions. Additionally, I am open to contributing to digital products like fintech solutions or interactive educational platforms, using my design background to create user-friendly, impactful tools. My long-term vision is to become an expert in human-centric design by creating versatile design solutions that have high utility, speak to the audience, and help achieve the underlying business objectives. UX research has potential to understand the undercurrent of consumers need—not just what they say they need—and to translate these ideas into tangible solutions. I also want to work in innovation strategy as it will enable me to zoom out the lens on entire ecosystems, and design solutions for long-term, sustainable impact.

The Human Centered Design & Engineering program at the University of Washington offers the ideal environment for me to cultivate my skills and achieve these goals. I am particularly drawn to the Accessibility and Inclusive Design and Usability Studies modules, which emphasize design thinking and the practical application of industry-relevant tools. With my previous work to uplift marginalized communities and promote heritage, the course on Designing Inclusive Interactions will be especially useful to enhance my understanding of building equitable, user-focused systems catering especially to those with disabilities or limited resources.

Along with this in-class learning, University of Washington is also renowned for its research-integrated teaching practice. Given my interest in creating affordable healthcare frameworks, I am especially keen to explore HCDE Design Use Build (DUB) Group's projects on accessibility, civic technology, and sustainability based digital tools and interfaces. The program's emphasis on experiential learning through industry collaborations, live projects, and its state-of-the-art Makeability Lab, The Momentary Experience Lab, and Inclusive Design Lab excites me as they provide an opportunity to experiment with emerging technologies such as IoT or AR/VR. Moreover, the University of Washington's collaborative atmosphere, which includes industry events, HCDE's annual Open House and Capstone Showcases, will provide opportunities to engage with like-minded peers and professionals and the platform to present my work to the industry at large.

Last but not the least, I was happy to discover The Taskar Center for Accessible Technology whose focus on inclusive technology design and development mirrors my own mission to develop products and services that address socio-economic inequities and improve overall quality of life.

By making full use of these and the numerous other opportunities on campus, I have no doubt that I will become an industry-ready professional, possessing the skills I need to achieve my goals.

Please provide a personal statement that responds to the following questions as a part of your scholarship application (maximum of 2,000 characters (approx. 350 words) response per question)

1. Describe how receiving a Postgraduate Scholarship would make a difference to you

Getting a postgraduate scholarship would be a transforming chance for me to completely concentrate on my academics and career goals free from the financial weight usually associated with a master's education abroad. This scholarship would help me to devote more time to academic study and professional development by easing the burden of living expenses and tuition fees and therefore lowering the necessity of part-time employment. Normally, having to find part-time work to cover expenses would take the focus away from my academic output's quality.

With industrial collaborations, live projects, and state-of-the-art facilities including the Service Futures Lab, Creative Technology Lab, and Digital Space, the University of the Arts London (UAL) presents a remarkable setting for invention. These tools offer the ideal basis for investigating newly developed technologies such as projection mapping and virtual reality. UAL's focus on practical projects and all of these facilities would let me thrive academically while working on industry-standard assignments, therefore enabling me to completely embrace this dedication without being distracted by any other responsibilities.

Apart from the set course of instruction, I am keen to participate in multidisciplinary learning and work across several domains. Investigating many fields, joining student unions and societies, and working with intellectually driven colleagues on projects like the UAL Creative Hackathon will deepen my academic path. Having the freedom to fully engage in these chances makes me sure I will graduate as an industry-ready professional with the tools and knowledge to reach my objectives free from needless distractions.

Apart from my schooling, this scholarship would enable me to significantly benefit society. Working with different user groups and creating significant projects in sectors such as healthcare access, sustainable solutions, and technical developments appeals to me. With the help of this scholarship, I would be one step closer to realizing that dream financially.

Service design excites me greatly; hence, this scholarship would help me to reduce my financial burden, freeing me to concentrate on producing a significant effect. The chance to be considered and enthralled by the possibilities this help could open makes me pleased.

2. Tell us how you intend to use the qualification you will be gaining to support your future plans *

A course in Service Design will allow me to approach projects holistically, evaluating results a lot more pragmatically instead of being overly ambitious. It will enable me to combine design, technology, and strategy to produce strong ideas for companies and communities. Creating service ecosystems that create easily available solutions for marginalized populations helps me to largely solve socioeconomic inequalities. Inspired by my prior work in Assam, I hope to create frameworks like skill-building digital platforms for rural artists or reasonably priced healthcare models.

Through the means of this course, I intend to acquire knowledge of human-centered design, approaches, and sociopolitical dynamics to create a solution. Working on real-world assignments and industry collaborations will help me to become proficient in tools relevant to the sector and new technology. My goal is to develop solutions that enhance equity, inclusion, and accessibility for marginalized groups by specializing in inclusive design, usability studies, and accessibility.

Over time, I hope to become a master in human-centric design by creating high-utility, user-oriented solutions fit for both corporate goals and society's demands. I aspire to help create inclusive and easily available solutions that raise the standard of living for many different user groups and sectors while being in leadership positions where I use research to identify strong consumer requirements and convert them into workable ideas.

Following my postgraduate education, I intend to be a Service Designer or Innovation Strategist working for creative companies like IDEO, Fjord, or Deloitte Digital. These businesses provide the ideal setting for me to put my knowledge in projects combining design, technology, and strategy into use. I want to be a known authority in human-centric design over time so that I can produce adaptable solutions that not only appeal to the audience but also help to have more general social influence.

This accreditation will give me the required basis to reach my objectives, so guaranteeing that my work stays original, inclusive, and transforming.

3. Describe your background and your academic experience *

Having earned my Bachelor's degree from the leading design institution in India, the National Institute of Design (NID), my design thinking, creativity, and critical problem-solving have been greatly influenced by a strong people-oriented perspective.

Throughout my academic journey, I have maintained a consistent scorecard and earned the Highest Scorer award in my graduating cohort. But while my GPA of 8.6 in my Bachelor's in Industrial Design provides a glimpse into my academic progress, I believe the essence of design goes beyond conventional grading metrics and is demonstrated through practical application and impact.

My graduation project with Grant Thornton, where I worked with Assamese indigenous bamboo artists to revive the endangered Japi crafts, was a turning point in my academic career. Immersion in their culture helped me to better appreciate community-driven design and its obvious influence. In another project, I rebuilt construction barricades to improve safety for pedestrians and vehicle operators. Using behavioral mapping, I found difficulties experienced by rickshaw/two-wheeler drivers and pedestrians, so I guided the design of a lightweight, highly visible barrier with simple installation and maintenance.

Beyond these, I have produced an instructional activity kit examining the effect of touch on self-identity for youngsters and a mechanical tool to increase productivity for garland suppliers, with the former being chosen for presentation and publication at the International Conference on Research into Design (ICoRD25). Every one of these encounters has strengthened my ability to tackle sensitive and challenging topics with a drive to find appropriate solutions.

From a bird's-eye perspective, all my projects have reiterated the interconnection of design, utility, and sustainability. This understanding has been further strengthened through my professional experiences—at Thinkonomers (HDL), where I learned the value of user feedback; at Pichkaari Design Studio, where I worked on rebranding and user flow enhancement; at Grant Thornton; and now as a UX/UI Designer at BRND Studio, where I manage end-to-end design and research for SaaS dashboards and educational platforms—this knowledge has been further reinforced. These encounters have informed my design philosophy: designing simple, user-first experiences that carefully combine human-centered knowledge with logic.

4. Describe how you would use the qualification to address challenges faced by society in your home country, upholding the values of social justice and environmental stewardship *

Service design has the potential to make services more inclusive, efficient, and sustainable, transforming their delivery and experience. Growing up in India with large amounts of human capital, I have often seen that, although there is no shortage of hard work, a lack of organized and simple mechanisms keeps that effort from having an actual impact. The difficulty is working smart rather than only harder.

From my experiences, small-scale businesses and the industry of traditional crafts clearly show some of the most obvious places this disparity exists, which hampers novel initiatives like corporate social responsibility programs too. Many local businesses and artists have wonderful abilities, but their work is often overlooked and underappreciated without well-designed systems linking them to the correct markets. By simplifying supply chains, integrating technology, and guaranteeing these companies can run sustainably while safeguarding cultural legacies, service design can help close this distance. Working with artists, I observed that merely altering the positioning and sale of their goods had a significant impact on their livelihoods.

Beyond this, service design can improve working conditions too. Many developing Indian companies battle ineffective processes, which cause employee burnout and disengagement. Companies require answers catered to their unique problems rather than imposing systems and structures fashioned for international companies. Service design offers a structure to reimagine these systems—balancing workloads, altering roles, and supporting a more effective, employee- and consumer-centric approach.

Public services also stand to be very much beneficial. For many user groups, complicated government processes and inaccessible infrastructures cause everyday hardships, as discovered during multiple projects. Whether by revamping these systems—digital interventions, process restructuring, or better information accessibility and strategy development—we may make necessary services more compassionate and user-friendly.

Equally important is the role that service design plays in environmental sustainability. Many times, India's rapid economic expansion comes at the cost of environmental well-being. Whether in waste management, urban planning, or responsible consumption, including sustainable practices in regular services will help us advance without sacrificing the earth. India has enormous potential; by using human-centered solutions, we can design systems that empower people, safeguard the environment, and produce significant, long-lasting change.

5. Confirm any other sources of funding you have, or have applied for, to meet the cost of your studies in the UK. *

I intend to finance my master's education with a full student loan, which will help me pay for my degree; it will cover accommodation expenditures during my time in the UK as well as tuition. Although I haven't yet formally filed for the loan, I intend to do so in due course to make sure my studies' financial needs are met. I have not yet found or sought any other financing sources at this point.

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Addressing STI Management Challenges Among Female Sex Workers in India

Abstract. I have always been passionate about tackling social issues that affect communities often neglected due to discrimination, stereotypes, and pre-defined societal norms. In one of my research projects, I took a holistic approach to explore societal systems and focused on the challenges faced by female sex workers (FSWs) in India. Through this work, I identified a significant gap: the lack of attention to the behaviors and systems of stakeholders involved in managing sexually transmitted infections (STIs) among FSWs and the limited awareness of STIs among FSWs themselves. This project aims to address these barriers by employing service design methodologies to improve access to healthcare facilities and enhance the effectiveness of STI-related interventions for FSWs.

1. Literature Review

Female sex workers (FSWs) in India encounter a multitude of healthcare access barriers, among which stigma, legal constraints, and a healthcare infrastructure not aligned with their needs severely limit their access to much-needed care. The discrimination against sex workers in India is deeply entrenched. Historically, by 1869, FSWs who tested positive for sexually transmitted infections (STIs) were imprisoned. As a result, many kept their profession a secret and refrained from getting tested due to concerns about social rejection and fear of incarceration. In the post-colonial era, the HIV crisis of the 1980s exposed significant shortcomings in the healthcare system and underscored the critical importance of STI prevention and public education [1].

Estimates suggest that FSWs in India contribute substantially to HIV transmission, accounting for 71,000 documented cases [2]. While several services are available to support FSWs, organizations like the Centre for Advanced Research and Development-Targeted Initiative (CARD-TI) have made strides in raising awareness and offering assistance [3]. However, the reach of such programs remains limited due to the fear of identity exposure and the persistent discrimination FSWs face.

The World Health Organization's (WHO) program for STI prevention emphasizes evidence-based services characterized by high quality, optimized processes and partnerships, data-driven decision-making, community engagement, and innovation [4]. Unfortunately, the protocols currently implemented in India fall short of these recommendations, necessitating an urgent reevaluation and enhancement of existing strategies to align with global best practices.

Socially, FSWs experience acute levels of isolation and limited access to vital support networks [5]. Economically, stigma restricts opportunities, trapping many in cycles of poverty and increasing their vulnerability to exploitation by clients and law enforcement [6]. Legally, FSWs face harassment and abuse from authorities with little to no judicial recourse [7]. From a healthcare perspective, fear of stigma discourages FSWs from seeking medical advice, resulting in untreated STIs and exacerbated health conditions due to discriminatory practices in healthcare settings [8]. On a personal level, persistent discrimination erodes their self-worth and mental health, contributing to low self-esteem and psychological distress [9].

In light of these challenges, this topic warrants urgent attention and action. A project focused on addressing the healthcare access barriers for FSWs in India can contribute to reducing the stigma they face, enhancing the effectiveness of public health interventions, and improving the overall quality of life for this marginalized population.

2. Proposed Research Methodology

Targeted research methods can be used to engage stakeholders in STI management for FSWs and understand the barriers in detail. Identifying obstacles as perceived by primary and secondary stakeholders will help collect tailored data to analyze the layers of systems around FSWs and STIs. According to a 2022 study, there are over 8 lakh identified female sex workers in India [10], though many remain unidentified due to intersectional stigma related to sex, gender, and patriarchal attitudes. Snowball sampling, which relies on trust-building with an initial participant, can help reach this hidden population.

Interviews with FSWs can highlight their perceptions of STIs and barriers to healthcare, while focus group discussions can compare the experiences of NGO-affiliated FSWs with those who are not. Observational studies at ART centers and ICTCs can provide insights into current treatment protocols, counseling practices, and challenges faced by STI counselors working with high-risk populations. [11]

Techniques such as fly-on-the-wall observation and immersive activities, effective in past projects with service-oriented populations, could reveal dynamics in healthcare interactions. This research aims to map the broader system around FSWs and identify key intervention points to improve their access to medical facilities.

3. Potential Outcomes and Challenges

In a previous project, sex workers mentioned their fear of going to hospitals alone due to the fear of judgment. With 1,160 "Suraksha Clinics" (STI/RTI clinics) in district-level government healthcare facilities, the NACO ensures STI services are free and adhere to uniform care standards in family planning and reproductive health [12]. A service could be developed to address the challenge of disseminating the right messages to the community through various existing and new channels and to create a companionship model to encourage them to access these services.

Potential challenges in addressing STIs among female sex workers (FSWs) include their discomfort in sharing personal details like residence or contact information due to societal stigma and fear of exposure. Leveraging technology for anonymous consultations could help FSWs seek medical advice discreetly. Collaborations between NGOs like CARD-TI and healthcare providers could also create trust-based models where NGOs act as intermediaries, facilitating access to healthcare [11]. The diagnostic process, involving personal interviews about sexual history and profession, may be distressing for FSWs. Training healthcare providers to handle sensitive topics empathetically could ease these interactions. Tools like flashcards or visual indicators could enable FSWs to share personal information more comfortably, fostering trust and improving engagement with healthcare systems.

In the past, I have worked with communities that are challenging to engage with due to factors such as building trust, identification of the right stakeholders, and communication barriers. However, for each target group, I have been motivated to tackle these challenges using unique research methodologies and creating solutions that benefit the community. With a background in research and design, I believe I can strengthen my existing knowledge at the postgraduate level, leveraging the knowledge gained to its fullest potential. This will allow me to take on more complex briefs, fostering personal growth and contributing to societal development through design challenges.

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Project Proposal:

ABSTRACT

I have always been passionate about tackling social issues that affect communities often neglected due to discrimination, stereotypes, and pre-defined societal norms. In one of my research projects, I took a holistic approach to explore societal systems and focused on the challenges faced by female sex workers (FSWs) in India. Through this work, I identified a significant gap: the lack of attention to the behaviors and systems of stakeholders involved in managing sexually transmitted infections (STIs) among FSWs and the limited awareness of STIs among FSWs themselves. This project aims to address these barriers by employing service design methodologies to improve access to healthcare facilities and enhance the effectiveness of STI-related interventions for FSWs.

RATIONALE

Female sex workers (FSWs) in India encounter a multitude of healthcare access barriers, among which stigma, legal constraints, and a healthcare infrastructure not aligned with their needs severely limit their access to much-needed care. The discrimination against sex workers in India is deeply entrenched. Historically, by 1869, FSWs who tested positive for sexually transmitted infections (STIs) were imprisoned. As a result, many kept their profession a secret and refrained from getting tested due to concerns about social rejection and fear of incarceration. In the post-colonial era, the HIV crisis of the 1980s exposed significant shortcomings in the healthcare system and underscored the critical importance of STI prevention and public education [1].

Estimates suggest that FSWs in India contribute substantially to HIV transmission, accounting for 71,000 documented cases [2]. While several services are available to support FSWs, organizations like the Centre for Advanced Research and Development-Targeted Initiative (CARD-TI) have made strides in raising awareness and offering assistance [3]. However, the reach of such programs remains limited due to the fear of identity exposure and the persistent discrimination FSWs face.

The World Health Organization's (WHO) program for STI prevention emphasizes evidence-based services characterized by high quality, optimized processes and partnerships, data-driven decision-making, community engagement, and innovation [4]. Unfortunately, the protocols currently implemented in India fall short of these recommendations, necessitating an urgent reevaluation and enhancement of existing strategies to align with global best practices.

Socially, FSWs experience acute levels of isolation and limited access to vital support networks [5]. Economically, stigma restricts opportunities, trapping many in cycles of poverty and increasing their vulnerability to exploitation by clients and law enforcement [6]. Legally, FSWs face harassment and abuse from authorities with little to no judicial recourse [7]. From a healthcare perspective, fear of stigma discourages FSWs from seeking medical advice, resulting in untreated STIs and exacerbated health conditions due to discriminatory practices in healthcare settings [8]. On a personal level, persistent discrimination erodes their self-worth and mental health, contributing to low self-esteem and psychological distress [9].

In light of these challenges, this topic warrants urgent attention and action. A project focused on addressing the healthcare access barriers for FSWs in India can contribute to reducing the stigma they face, enhancing the effectiveness of public health interventions, and improving the overall quality of life for this marginalized population.

METHODOLOGY

Targeted research methods can be used to engage stakeholders in STI management for FSWs and understand the barriers in detail. Identifying obstacles as perceived by primary and secondary stakeholders will help collect tailored data to analyze the layers of systems around FSWs and STIs. According to a 2022 study, there are over 8 lakh identified female sex workers in India [10], though many remain unidentified due to intersectional stigma related to sex, gender, and patriarchal attitudes. Snowball sampling, which relies on trust-building with an initial participant, can help reach this hidden population.

Interviews with FSWs can highlight their perceptions of STIs and barriers to healthcare, while focus group discussions can compare the experiences of NGO-affiliated FSWs with those who are not. Observational studies at ART centers and ICTCs can provide insights into current treatment protocols, counseling practices, and challenges faced by STI counselors working with high-risk populations. [11]

Techniques such as fly-on-the-wall observation and immersive activities, effective in past projects with service-oriented populations, could reveal dynamics in healthcare interactions. This research aims to map the broader system around FSWs and identify key intervention points to improve their access to medical facilities.

POTENTIAL OUTCOMES

In a previous project, sex workers mentioned their fear of going to hospitals alone due to the fear of judgment. With 1,160 "Suraksha Clinics" (STI/RTI clinics) in district-level government healthcare facilities, the NACO ensures STI services are free and adhere to uniform care standards in family planning and reproductive health [12]. A service could be developed to address the challenge of disseminating the right messages to the community through various existing and new channels and to create a companionship model to encourage them to access these services.

Potential challenges in addressing STIs among female sex workers (FSWs) include their discomfort in sharing personal details like residence or contact information due to societal stigma and fear of exposure. Leveraging technology for anonymous consultations could help FSWs seek medical advice discreetly. Collaborations between NGOs like CARD-TI and healthcare providers could also create trust-based models where NGOs act as intermediaries, facilitating access to healthcare [11]. The diagnostic process, involving personal interviews about sexual history and profession, may be distressing for FSWs. Training healthcare providers to handle sensitive topics empathetically could ease these interactions. Tools like flashcards or visual indicators could enable FSWs to share personal information more comfortably, fostering trust and improving engagement with healthcare systems.

In the past, I have worked with communities that are challenging to engage with due to factors such as building trust, identification of the right stakeholders, and communication barriers. However, for each target group, I have been motivated to tackle these challenges using unique research methodologies and creating solutions that benefit the community. With a background in research and design, I believe I can strengthen my existing knowledge at the postgraduate level, leveraging the knowledge gained to its fullest potential. This will allow me to take on more complex briefs, fostering personal growth and contributing to societal development through design challenges.

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STATEMENT OF PURPOSE

Growing up in Bangalore, life unfolded in straight lines and stark edges, where every structure was a servant of purpose, and aesthetics took a backseat to utility. It wasn't until I wandered through the vibrant streets of Barcelona, on a trip during high school, that I discovered the quiet poetry of aesthetics in public spaces.

As I took on design assignments during undergraduate studies, I discovered it also had the power to effect social change. What reinforced this was my on-site graduation project in collaboration with Grant Thornton, where I worked with the indigenous bamboo artisans from Assam to revive the endangered practice of crafting a Japi. Immersing myself in the local culture deepened my understanding of community-driven design and its impact on artisans and customers alike. From redesigning construction barricades and creating an educational activity kit to teaching children about personal boundaries to developing a mechanical tool for flower vendors, my bachelor's in Industrial Design has reiterated the interconnection of design and community. This understanding has been further strengthened through my work at Thinkonomers (HDL), where I learned to apply user feedback in the design process; Pichkaari Design Studio, where I worked on rebranding projects and developed user flow enhancement prototypes; Grant Thornton; and finally, in my current role as a UX/UI designer at BRND Studio, where I handle end-to-end design for SaaS dashboards, educational platforms, and teaching tools. These experiences have amalgamated into my design philosophy, based on creating superlative experiences for both virtual and real spaces, and coalesced into my chosen career path in Information Experience Design.

After graduate studies, I plan to work as a UX Researcher or Innovation Strategist with creative firms like Google or Huge Inc. on projects that blend strategy, design, and technology. My long-term vision is to become an expert in human-centric design by creating versatile design solutions that have high utility, speak to the audience, and help achieve the underlying business objectives. Inspired by my Japi Art project, I aim to work on service ecosystems that address socio-economic inequities by co-creating accessible services like affordable healthcare frameworks or skill-building digital platforms for marginalized communities and rural artisans.

The MS Information Experience Design program at Pratt is the perfect conduit for this. I am particularly interested in the Practical Ethnography for User Experience, Speculative Design, and Information Architecture, which encourage design thinking and conversance with industry-relevant tools. Pratt's emphasis on experiential learning through industry collaborations and live projects, and its state-of-the-art Semantic Lab and Observation Room, provide an ideal environment for me to try my hand at emerging technologies like usability machines. I am excited to collaborate with the intellectually spirited student cohort for the Pratt Design Challenge and engage in team-based innovation to devise solutions for contemporary social and environmental challenges. By making full use of these and the numerous other opportunities on campus, I do not doubt that I will become an industry-ready professional, possessing the skills I need to achieve my goals.

RCA - Video Task script

We ask that you upload a two-minute video recorded on your phone or laptop, speaking to us directly. High production qualities are not needed. We will review the work in your portfolio, so keep your video simple.

In your video, please explain your motivation to be a service designer and provide an example of your favourite service experience. Please then describe an aspect of Service Design you are most passionate about. Finally, briefly describe your favourite project in your portfolio and why you chose it.

This will be a chance to showcase your understanding of Service Design, your passion for studying at a Master's level and your ability to communicate the value and impact of your work.

Points to cover -

- Motivation to be a service designer and an example of my favourite service example
- An aspect of service design that I am most passionate about
- Describe your favourite project in your portfolio and why you chose it

Script

I'm Rachit Singhi, an industrial designer with a passion for creating thoughtful, impactful design experiences and solutions.

Growing up in Bangalore, I was surrounded by residential and corporate complexes with more focus on utility than aesthetics. It wasn't until I visited Barcelona, for a high school trip, that I discovered the quiet poetry of aesthetics in public spaces. As I took on co-curricular design assignments during undergraduate studies, I discovered art also had the power to effect social change. One project that truly reinforced this was my on-site research with Grant Thornton, where I worked with indigenous bamboo artisans from Assam to revive the endangered Japi craft. Through this and several other community and people-oriented projects I have understood that design has a unique ability to identify problems, craft solutions, and create smooth, user-centred experiences.

But this process requires deep research and analysis of the user's ecosystem, along with careful attention to where the most impactful changes can happen. I especially noted this during a unique project I undertook - "The Life-Saving Dot," also known as Jeevan Bindi - a decorative vermilion mark adorned on the forehead by Indian women. My project blended culture, health, and technology, by integrating salt into the traditional bindi and seeking to naturally remedy the iodine deficiency problem in rural India. Similarly, my research into STI management practices among female sex workers in Bhopal highlighted the intersection of design, public health, and social justice, giving a voice to marginalized communities decidedly overlooked in policymaking.

What I loved most about all these projects and about service design as a field at large, is that I get to work across disciplines, ideate like a tree and branch out through research and analysis that oftentimes leads to novel and innovative outcomes.

My motivation to be a service designer stems from this ability to blend empathy, creativity, and systemic thinking. I look forward to contributing to and learning from RCA's dynamic community, where I hope to refine my skills and create solutions that matter.

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But this process requires deep research and analysis of the user's ecosystem, along with careful attention to where the most impactful changes can happen. I saw this when I came across an interesting campaign called "The Life-Saving Dot," also known as Jeevan Bindi - a decorative vermillion mark adorned on the forehead by Indian women. What intrigued me was how the final product blended culture, health, and technology, by integrating salt into the traditional bindi and seeking to naturally remedy the iodine deficiency problem in rural India. I got the chance to apply a similar model to my project on STI management practices among female sex workers in Bhopal. The project was placed at the intersection of design, public health, and social justice, giving a voice to marginalized communities decidedly overlooked in policymaking.

What I loved most about all these projects and about service design as a field at large, is that I get to work across disciplines, ideate like a tree and branch out through research and analysis that oftentimes leads to novel and innovative outcomes.

My motivation to be a service designer stems from this ability to blend empathy, creativity, and systemic thinking. I look forward to contributing to and learning from RCA's dynamic community, where I hope to refine my skills and create solutions that matter.

STATEMENT OF PURPOSE

Growing up in Bangalore, I was surrounded by structures focused more on utility than aesthetics. However, my travels to heritage sites in India introduced me to the profound impact of visual and experiential design. This realisation deepened through my undergraduate studies in Industrial Design, where I explored how design can drive social change. My work with indigenous bamboo artisans from Assam reinforced my belief that design doesn't just change environments—it transforms lives, as I aimed to revive the endangered craft of Japi. Integrating user research and analyzing ecosystems taught me how design interventions can create meaningful, lasting impacts. During this time, I have explored the design process in areas like innovative product development, user-centric methodologies, and systems thinking. This ability to use scientific advancements to create new products and services that drive business and economy and, at the same time, make people's lives easier and more comfortable is something that excites and motivates me to build a long-term career in this field. I now wish to augment my portfolio and train my design thinking mindset to scope, refine, and deliver practicable solutions and translate abstract ideas, theories, and plans into practice through an MS in Information Experience Design.

From a bird's-eye perspective, all my projects have reiterated the interconnection of design, utility, and sustainability. My academic and professional journey has been shaped by diverse experiences across industries and disciplines. From redesigning construction barricades and creating educational activity kits that explore the impact of touch on self-identity (paper selection in ICoRD – International Conference on Research into Design) to developing mechanical tools for flower vendors, my projects have consistently emphasised the intersection of design, usability, and community impact. My work at Thinkonomers (HDL) strengthened my ability to integrate user feedback into the design process, while my role at Pichkaari Design Studio exposed me to branding and user flow enhancements. At Grant Thornton, I worked on service-orientated design strategies, and my current role as a UX/UI designer at BRND Studio involves handling end-to-end design for SaaS dashboards, educational platforms, and teaching tools. These experiences have shaped my design philosophy, emphasizing human-centered solutions.

Information Experience Design, for me, is a powerful tool to improve ineffective processes, streamline complex systems, and enhance accessibility, especially in the context of India. My work with female sex workers in Bhopal highlighted the need for better service ecosystems, as I observed how complicated government procedures and inaccessible infrastructure create everyday hardships. Whether by revamping physical spaces or designing user-friendly digital interfaces, I believe design can make essential services more approachable and inclusive. Similarly, in business contexts, I have observed that reimaging workflows can effectively reduce employee burnout and disengagement, highlighting the importance of customised, research-driven solutions over generic approaches.

Sustainability is another area where Information Experience Design holds immense potential. Rapid economic expansion in developing countries often comes at an environmental cost, but design can bridge the gap between progress and sustainability. Whether in waste management, urban planning, or responsible consumption, innovative service design solutions can help us grow without sacrificing the planet's well-being.

Post-graduation, I aspire to work as an Experience Designer, UX Researcher, or Innovation Strategist where I can follow, build, and reiterate my design philosophies and principles to drive impactful solutions. In the long term, I aim to specialize in human-centric design, creating inclusive, high-utility frameworks that address socio-economic disparities. For example, inspired by my work in Assam, I envision designing service ecosystems such as skill-building digital platforms for rural artisans or accessible healthcare frameworks for marginalized communities.

RCA - MA Service Design

Requirements -

Please provide a 300-word written personal statement that addresses the following points:

- 1. Introduce yourself, your interests, and your motivations for applying to the Royal College of Art, and to this program in particular.**
- 2. Briefly summarise any educational background and professional experience to date that will support your application.**
- 3. Tell us what you want to do in the future.**

Growing up in Bangalore, life unfolded in straight lines and stark edges, where every structure was a servant of purpose, and aesthetics took a backseat to utility. It wasn't until I wandered through the vibrant streets of Barcelona, on a trip during high school, that I discovered the quiet poetry of aesthetics in public spaces. This revelation stirred a deep admiration within me during those early years and led me to pursue a degree in design for my undergraduate education.

As I took on design assignments in college, I increasingly saw that it also had the unique power to effect social change. What reinforced this was my on-site graduation project in collaboration with Grant Thornton, where I worked with the indigenous bamboo artisans from Assam to revive the endangered practice of crafting a Japi. Immersing myself in the local culture deepened my understanding of community-driven design and its impact on the artisan and the other stakeholders associated with it. From developing a mechanical tool for garland weaving that improved the efficiency and comfort of flower vendors to creating an educational activity kit exploring the impact of a bad touch on self-identity for children, (the latter is selected for presentation and publication at the International Conference on Research into Design - ICoRD'25), all my projects have reiterated the interconnection of design, community, and sustainability.

This has coalesced into my chosen career path in Service Design. After graduate studies, I plan to work as a Service Designer or Innovation Strategist with creative firms like IDEO, Fjord, or Deloitte Digital, on projects that blend strategy, design, and technology. My long-term vision is to become an expert in looking at design not just from a human-centric approach but a holistic systems-thinking perspective that keeps in mind the ecosystem and sub-players around a user by creating versatile design solutions that have high utility, speak to the audience, and help achieve the underlying business objectives.

The MA Service Design program at RCA is the perfect conduit to materialize these. I am particularly interested in the Service Design Practice and Service Design in Context modules, which encourage interdisciplinary design thinking and conversance with industry-relevant tools. RCA's emphasis on practical learning through industry collaborations, and live projects, and its state-of-the-art Computing & Technology (CAT) Zones provide an ideal environment for me to experiment with emerging technologies. I am excited to collaborate with the intellectually spirited student cohort for the AcrossRCA modules and engage in team-based innovation to devise solutions for contemporary social and environmental challenges. By making full use of these and the numerous other opportunities on campus, I do not doubt that I will become an industry-ready professional, possessing the skills I need to achieve my goals.

RCA - Video Task script

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In your video, please explain your motivation to be a service designer and provide an example of your favourite service experience. Please then describe an aspect of Service Design you are most passionate about. Finally, briefly describe your favourite project in your portfolio and why you chose it.

This will be a chance to showcase your understanding of Service Design, your passion for studying at a Master's level and your ability to communicate the value and impact of your work.

Points to cover -

- Motivation to be a service designer and an example of my favourite service example
- An aspect of service design that I am most passionate about
- Describe your favourite project in your portfolio and why you chose it

Script

I'm Rachit Singhi, an industrial designer with a passion for creating thoughtful, impactful design experiences and solutions. During my time in college, as I worked on various design projects, I realized how design can drive societal change. It became clear to me that design has a unique ability to identify problems, craft solutions, and create smooth, user-centered experiences. One of my internships helped me understand just how important it is to identify pain points, understand the environment around the user, and then develop effective solutions. This process requires deep research and analysis of the user's ecosystem, along with careful attention to where the most impactful changes can happen. These experiences helped shape my design philosophy, which eventually led me to focus on service design.

Service design excites me because it blends creativity, empathy, and strategy to address both tangible and intangible challenges. What drives me is the chance to solve real-world problems through human-centered innovation. A great example of this is "The Life-Saving Dot," also known as Jeevan Bindi. This is a decorative mark worn on the forehead by Indian women, especially Hindus. The project addresses iodine deficiency in rural India by embedding iodine into the traditional bindi. It blends culture, health, and technology, creating a solution that fits seamlessly into daily life. It removes barriers like taking pills or frequent doctor visits. This project demonstrates key principles of service design, like working across disciplines, changing behavior through culturally sensitive design, and creating scalable, sustainable solutions. Its simplicity and impact show how powerful it is to design with empathy and consider the context.

One thing that excites me about service design is the uncertainty that persists throughout the process. The design doesn't start with a clear direction. Instead, research and analysis lead to an opportunity area for intervention, which can be very multidisciplinary and sometimes totally different from what we expected.

A project that brought all of these ideas together for me was the Analysis of STI Management Practices, Awareness Levels, and Access Barriers among Female Sex Workers in Bhopal. This project stands out because it combined rigorous research with meaningful social impact. It allowed me to collaborate with a variety of stakeholders to find the best solution. I chose this project because it focused on a critical public health issue and gave a voice to a marginalized group, often overlooked in policymaking. It also taught me a lot about addressing difficult social challenges.

SCAD - MA in Service Design

The form has individual questions that we need to answer in 250 words and a requirement for an SOP.

Why do you want to attend SCAD? * (250 words max)

Over the past five years, my learnings have coalesced into my chosen career path in Service design. After graduate studies, I plan to work as a Service Designer or Innovation Strategist with creative firms like Deloitte Digital, or Fjords, on projects that blend strategy, design, and technology. Specifically, I aim to work on service ecosystems that address pressing socio-economic inequities by co-creating accessible services for marginalized communities - such as affordable healthcare frameworks or skill-building digital platforms for rural artisans, inspired by my earlier work in Assam. I am also open to working on digital products like fintech solutions, or interactive educational platforms. My long-term vision is to become an expert in human-centric design by creating versatile design solutions that have high utility, speak to the audience, and help achieve the underlying business objectives.

The MA in service design program at SCAD is the perfect conduit to materialize these. I am particularly interested in the Mixed Methods Research, Visualizing Services, and Systemic Innovation for Service Evolution modules which encourage design thinking and conversance with industry relevant tools. SCAD's emphasis on practical learning through industry collaborations, live projects, and its state-of-the-art Gulfstream Center, model shop, and Computer labs provide an ideal environment for me to experiment with emerging technologies such as AR/VR and Immersive media. I am excited to collaborate with the intellectually spirited student cohort for the SCAD Challenge and engage in team-based innovation to devise solutions for contemporary social and environmental challenges. By making full use of these and the numerous other opportunities on campus, I have no doubt that I will become an industry-ready professional, possessing the skills I need to achieve my goals.

Who is your favorite artist/designer and why? 250 word max

Amongst pioneers of human-centered service design, the person who inspires me most is Steve Krug. His seminal work, *Don't Make Me Think*, a book on web usability, has profoundly shaped my understanding of designing for seamless experiences. Krug's philosophy is radical in its simplicity: services should be intuitive, reducing friction rather than adding complexity. I take from this that good service design should focus on clarity, ensuring that interactions—both digital and physical—are as effortless as possible. Krug emphasizes usability principles such as clear hierarchies and intuitive pathways, which I have adapted to my work by prioritizing service flows that are frictionless, efficient, and aligned with user needs.

Like many who start in the field, I initially focused on individual touchpoints, attempting to refine specific interactions without fully considering the broader service ecosystem. Over time, through practice, feedback, and learning from my missteps, I realized that impactful service design requires a holistic approach—understanding user journeys, eliminating inefficiencies, and designing systems that serve users in a way that feels natural and unobtrusive. This shift in perspective aligns with Krug's advocacy for removing unnecessary barriers and ensuring that services work so well that they become almost invisible to the user.

I was fortunate to find a mentor who shares these values—Mr. Sudhir Bhatia, the founder of BRND, my current studio. His approach to service design emphasizes that a well-designed system functions like a well-oiled machine; it may not always be the most visually striking from the outside, but it operates seamlessly, ensuring that every interaction contributes to a cohesive and effective experience. Working with him has reinforced my belief that service design is not just about optimizing interfaces but about orchestrating entire systems to serve people better.

While I do not have an absolute favorite influence, the teachings of Krug and the mentorship of Bhatia have profoundly shaped my design ethos. By studying their work and integrating their methodologies, I strive to create services that prioritize ease of use, reduce cognitive load, and ultimately enhance the lives of those who interact with them.

How will your life and/or professional experience impact your ability to succeed at SCAD? 250 word max

My Bachelor's degree from India's premier design school National Institute of Design (NID), has given my design thought, creativity and critical thinking a decisively humane and people-oriented direction. It introduced me to three facets of design: systems design, service design, and interaction design – each with its unique applications that called for deeper exploration. The systems approach calls for looking at a problem area holistically before identifying an intervention type, service design relies on solving design problems with the aid of techno-digital interventions, whereas interaction designs shed light on making such designs more user-centric.

As I took on design assignments in college, I increasingly saw that it also had the unique power to effect social change. What reinforced this was my on-site graduation project in collaboration with Grant Thornton where I worked with indigenous bamboo artisans from Assam to revive endangered Japi crafts. Immersing myself in the local culture deepened my understanding of community-driven design and the impact it can have on the artisan as well as a customer. In another project, I redesigned construction barricades to improve safety for pedestrians during peak traffic hours. I used behavioral mapping to understand challenges around their installation, inconveniences faced by Rickshaw and Two-Wheeler drivers navigating around them, or pedestrians crossing near construction zones. After a few rounds of on-ground testing of the full-scale prototype, I succeeded in designing a lightweight, highly visible barricade that was easy to install, maintain, and store.

From developing a mechanical tool for garland weaving that improved the efficiency and comfort of flower vendors to creating an educational activity kit exploring self-identity for children (the latter is selected for presentation and publication at the International Conference on Research into Design - ICoRD'25), all my projects have reiterated the interconnection of design, community, and sustainability.

From a bird's eye perspective, all my projects have reiterated the interconnection of design, utility, and sustainability. This understanding has been further strengthened through my professional experiences - at Thinkonomers (HDL) where I learned about the importance of user feedback in the design process, Pichkaari Design Studio, where I worked on rebranding projects and developed user flow enhancement prototypes, Grant Thornton, and finally in my current role as a UX/UI designer at BRND Studio, where I handle end-to-end design for SaaS dashboards, educational platforms, and

teaching tools. These experiences have ingrained in me that user experience should be the top priority in the design process and helped shape my own design philosophy, which is based on creating superlative, easy to use experiences for modern spaces, both virtual and real. For example, in my initial projects, I dove headfirst into design but with experience and trial and error, I realised that logic in design will hold little value unless it is thoughtfully integrated with an intuitive understanding of how it will be used by humans.

Do you feel your grades and/or test scores accurately reflect your potential to succeed at SCAD? If not, why? 250 word max

I believe my test scores accurately reflect my potential to succeed at SCAD as both a designer and a student. Throughout my academic journey, I have maintained a strong commitment to excellence, ensuring that I give my 100% to every project, whether in college or in the industry. Being awarded as the highest scorer in my batch is a testament to my dedication, discipline, and ability to apply design thinking rigorously.

Beyond academic achievements, my success stems from a problem-solving mindset and an iterative approach to design. As a service designer, I thrive on dissecting complex systems, understanding user behaviors, and crafting holistic solutions that are functional, user-centric, and sustainable. My projects—ranging from revitalizing indigenous crafts to designing intuitive digital experiences—demonstrate my ability to integrate strategic thinking with creative execution. These skills extend beyond grades; they reflect my ability to approach challenges with curiosity, adaptability, and a keen sense of human-centered design.

While grades are a measure of academic success, I believe true potential is demonstrated through practical application and impact. My work on projects such as redesigning safety infrastructure, developing community-driven service solutions, and enhancing user experience in digital platforms highlights my ability to bridge the gap between design theory and real-world implementation.

My academic performance, combined with hands-on experience in service and interaction design, assures me that I have the skills, discipline, and mindset to thrive at SCAD. I am eager to refine my expertise and contribute meaningfully to SCAD's dynamic design community.

Statement of Purpose? 500-750 word max

Your statement should give an overview of your academic and personal experience, describing preparation for and commitment to further study at SCAD, as well as educational and professional aspirations.

I am not sure what to put in the statement of purpose because I have used the SOP master for answering the questions above

Growing up in Bangalore, life unfolded in straight lines and stark edges, where every structure was a servant of purpose, and aesthetics took a backseat to utility. It wasn't until I wandered through the vibrant streets of Barcelona, for a trip during high school, that I discovered the quiet poetry of

aesthetics in public spaces. This revelation stirred a deep admiration within me during those early years. My ensuing creative practice has been shaped by my undergraduate studies in Industrial Design and diverse professional experiences. In this time, I have explored the design process in areas like innovative product development, user-centric methodologies, and systems thinking. This ability to use scientific advancements to create new products and services that drive business and economy and at the same time make people's lives easier and more comfortable is something that excites and motivates me to build a long-term career in this field. I now wish to augment my portfolio and train my design thinking mindset to scope, refine and deliver practicable solutions and translate abstract ideas, theories and plans into practice through an MA in Service Design.

This academic goal is a well-thought-out progression of my interests and skillset. I have always loved art and craft as a young boy and knew that I wanted to work in a field that would allow me to express my creativity and challenge me intellectually. My Bachelor's degree from India's premier design school National Institute of Design (NID), has given my design thought, creativity and critical thinking a decisively humane and people-oriented direction. It introduced me to three facets of design: systems design, service design, and interaction design – each with its unique applications that called for deeper exploration. The systems approach calls for looking at a problem area holistically before identifying an intervention type, service design relies on solving design problems with the aid of techno-digital interventions, whereas interaction designs shed light on making such designs more user-centric.

As I took on design assignments in college, I increasingly saw that it also had the unique power to effect social change. What reinforced this was my on-site graduation project in collaboration with Grant Thornton where I worked with indigenous bamboo artisans from Assam to revive endangered Japi crafts. Immersing myself in the local culture deepened my understanding of community-driven design and the impact it can have on the artisan as well as a customer. In another project, I redesigned construction barricades to improve safety for pedestrians during peak traffic hours. I used behavioral mapping to understand challenges around their installation, inconveniences faced by Rickshaw and Two-Wheeler drivers navigating around them, or pedestrians crossing near construction zones. After a few rounds of on-ground testing of the full-scale prototype, I succeeded in designing a lightweight, highly visible barricade that was easy to install, maintain, and store.

In another creative project, I designed a mechanical tool for garland weaving that improved the efficiency and comfort of flower vendors. My hometown Bengaluru, and my study domicile Madhya Pradesh, are both renowned for their temple heritage where millions of devotees offer flowers for worship, in turn leading to a booming flower industry. Observing the beautiful garland creations of the vendors I also noticed many of them faced repetitive strain injuries due to manual weaving techniques. Using a participatory design approach, I co-created an ingenious tool that at once remedied the physical duress of the weaving and enhanced the speed and productivity of the garland weavers.

Prior to this, I worked on two tech-intensive projects. The first was an analysis of STI management practices, awareness levels, and barriers restricting access to services among female sex workers (FSWs) in Bhopal. Employing the snowball sampling technique, I was able to locate their work zones. But this was only the beginning - the real challenge was gaining their trust and convincing them of the larger social purpose of my work. The research-heavy nature of the project further complicated the process but using methods like GIGA mapping user journeys, and iceberg models, we developed a

customized Trigger and Response Model to comprehend the data and interpret findings more effectively. The resultant research provided recommendations for community-centric support systems, such as mobile clinics and awareness programs. In the second project, I created an educational activity kit exploring self-identity for children. Using techniques like user journey mapping, participatory testing, and iterative prototyping, I built a fun tool to help children understand and express their feelings. My research paper on the same selected for presentation and publication at the International Conference on Research into Design - ICoRD'25.

From a bird's eye perspective, all my projects have reiterated the interconnection of design, utility, and sustainability. This understanding has been further strengthened through my professional experiences - at Thinkonomers (HDL) where I learned about the importance of user feedback in the design process, Pichkaari Design Studio, where I worked on rebranding projects and developed user flow enhancement prototypes, Grant Thornton, and finally in my current role as a UX/UI designer at BRND Studio, where I handle end-to-end design for SaaS dashboards, educational platforms, and teaching tools. These experiences have ingrained in me that user experience should be the top priority in the design process and helped shape my own design philosophy, which is based on creating superlative, easy to use experiences for modern spaces, both virtual and real. For example, in my initial projects, I dove headfirst into design but with experience and trial and error, I realised that logic in design will hold little value unless it is thoughtfully integrated with an intuitive understanding of how it will be used by humans.

Collectively, these five years of formative learnings have coalesced into my chosen career path in **Service Design**. After graduate studies, I plan to work as a Service Designer or Innovation Strategist with creative firms like **Deloitte Digital, Fjord, or IDEO**, on projects that blend strategy, design, and technology. Specifically, I aim to work on service ecosystems that address pressing socio-economic inequities by co-creating accessible services for marginalized communities—such as affordable healthcare frameworks or skill-building digital platforms for rural artisans, inspired by my earlier work in Assam. I am also open to working on digital products like fintech solutions or interactive educational platforms. My long-term vision is to become an expert in human-centric design by creating versatile design solutions that have high utility, speak to the audience, and help achieve the underlying business objectives.

The **MA in Service Design** program at **SCAD** is the perfect conduit to materialize these. I am particularly interested in the **Mixed Methods Research, Visualizing Services, and Systemic Innovation for Service Evolution** modules, which encourage design thinking and conversance with industry-relevant tools. **SCAD's** emphasis on practical learning through industry collaborations, live projects, and its state-of-the-art **Gulfstream Center, model shop, and computer labs** provide an ideal environment for me to experiment with emerging technologies such as **AR/VR and immersive media**. I am excited to collaborate with the intellectually spirited student cohort for the **SCAD Challenge** and engage in team-based innovation to devise solutions for contemporary social and environmental challenges. By making full use of these and the numerous other opportunities on campus, I have no doubt that I will become an industry-ready professional, possessing the skills I need to achieve my goals.

Script for subtitles

Hi, I'm Rachit Singhi. An industrial designer who is extremely passionate about creating impactful and thoughtful design experiences and solutions.

Growing up in Bangalore, I was surrounded by residential and corporate complexes with more attention to utility than aesthetics. It wasn't until I visited Barcelona, for my high school trip, that I discovered the quiet poetry of aesthetics even in public spaces. As I took on co-curricular design assignments during my undergraduate studies, I discovered that design also had the power to effect social change. This was truly reinforced during my on-site graduation project with Grant Thornton Bharat, that gave me the opportunity to work with the indigenous bamboo artisans from Assam to revive the endangered Japi craft. Through this and several other community and people-oriented projects, I have understood that design has a unique ability to identify problems, craft solutions, and create smooth, user-centered experiences.

However, this process requires deep research, an analysis of a user's ecosystem, and careful attention to where an impactful change can happen. I saw this when I came across an interesting campaign called "The Life-Saving Dot," or the Jeevan Bindi—a decorative mark worn by the Indian women on their foreheads. What intrigued me about this project was that the final product blended health, technology, and culture extremely seamlessly by integrating salt into the traditional bindi and coming up with a remedy for the iodine deficiency problem in rural India. I got the chance to apply a similar model to my design project, which focused on STI management practices among female sex workers in Bhopal. The project was placed at an intersection of design, public health, and social change, giving a voice to the marginalized communities decidedly overlooked in policymaking.

What I love most about these projects and service design as a field at large is that I get to work across disciplines, ideate like a tree, and branch out through research and analysis that oftentimes give me novel and innovative design solutions.

My motivation to be a service designer stems from this ability to blend creativity, empathy, and systemic thinking. I look forward to contributing and learning from RCA's dynamic community, where I can refine my skills and create solutions that actually matter.

Hi, I am Rachit Singhi. A user-centered industrial designer who is extremely passionate about creating impactful and thoughtful design experiences and solutions. With the same motive in mind, I had the opportunity to work as a summer trainee in Grant Thornton Bharat, which is an organization that primarily provides services to the business sectors like auditing and accounting.

One such service that the organization also provides is by collaborating with multiple rural stakeholders as part of their corporate social responsibility program. This is where I had the opportunity as a designer to work with the organization and collaborate with the bamboo artisans of Assam, which is an economically backward state in India, for a duration of six months. I spent my time in the cluster understanding the crafting techniques used by the artisans to make a Japi, which is a traditional bamboo hat worn by the people of Assam, and developed two product ranges which were derived from these already-known crafting techniques by the artisans but had a higher market appeal, and as a result, could increase the revenue generation and income for these artisans. Although I was very quick to realize the loopholes that existed that existed in the entire project in the first month itself.

Considering I wasn't the first to conduct such training with the artisans, it raised an important question: Why had the previous training not been effective? This question opened up a can of worms, allowing me to examine the entire project a lot more holistically. I began questioning whether simply having an output that the organization thinks is impactful was enough or was it far more important to consider how to deliver that output to maximize its impact, considering what the key stakeholders are looking for from such interventions and training given to them.

And hence, this project became a lens through which I understood the importance of service design. It highlighted the importance of not developing a solution for the identified problem area until proper research has been undertaken with all of the players involved in the ecosystem. Instead of taking a top-down approach to training deployment, I took a bottom-up approach to training needs assessment. With this approach in mind, I reassessed the designs of product development that were being taught to these artisans during these training sessions and instead developed designs that didn't feel as alien to them and had a sense of belongingness to the Japi.

This project highlighted the idea that having a solution isn't enough; but rather, how the intervention is delivered can make all the difference in achieving a meaningful impact that actually sticks and can be applied to a real-world scenario.

SOP Questionnaire

NOTE

- Please don't blandly describe what you have done in the past; instead focus on what you have learnt through those actions
- Your answers to question under **Future Goals** section are very important
- Do not copy paste anything from the CV. We already have a copy of your CV. Instead focus on the stories behind the activities
- Quantify achievements/events and be very clear about timelines

Please answer the following questions to help draft your SOP / essay

ABOUT YOU

Q1a – Why did you pick your current field/degree and how long have you been associated with the field (100 words maximum)

- The core of industrial design is solving problems, and how one solves that problem is driven by research and interacting with people. Industrial design is a multidisciplinary approach that can involve creating digital/tangible products, working with materials, or solving problems through strategies like systems design.
- Since childhood, I've been drawn to working with materials, whether it's a single piece of cardboard or a scrap of cloth, all for personal fulfillment. At the same time I was unknowingly drawn to the basics of digital design via school projects or extracurricular activities like making a short film or designing a flyer, where we had to convey a message visually and effectively. Lastly, I've always been passionate about talking to people. In school, I was part of the "National Service Scheme," where we visited a hospital for mentally challenged individuals, a first experience of such for me. There, I discovered how much joy I find in conversing with people and hearing stories and experiences that I might never encounter again.
- After my first year, I was unsure about which specialization to choose. My faculty suggested Industrial Design, which combines people interaction, product design, and digital design—exactly the blend I was looking for.

OR

Q1b – When did you decide to change career track? What was the trigger for the change? (100 words maximum)

Guidelines to answer

- If you're changing fields (e.g. shifting from Engineering to Finance or Finance to Marketing etc.) answer question 1b else answer 1a
- Try to provide some small incident/trigger for the field of choice

(I am not exactly changing fields - but I am choosing a subset of industrial design)

1. Service design

What attracts me most to service design is that it shares similarities with industrial design—it's flexible, solution-centric, and allows for entering a project with ambiguity, letting research guide the end product. Additionally, it is highly multidisciplinary, fostering cross-learning from various design practices.

My decision to pursue service design stems from a personal experience. During my six-month graduation project, I was given a design brief from an organization to create two product ranges from bamboo, a material already used by local craftsmen. The goal was to introduce and train them in modern product designs that could sell better in the

market. A secondary deliverable was to train the wives of these artisans to expand their involvement in the craft and teach them ways to improve marketability.

During my research, I realized that while the organization had clear goals and deliverables, the real issue lay elsewhere. Previous training failed because they didn't focus on the cultural preservation of the craft or on empowering artisans to make decisions. This gap between what artisans wanted and what organizations were providing made me realize that companies need to consider not just what they deliver, but how they deliver it for the greatest impact.

(Not sure if this would go in the SOP or the essays)

2. Interaction Design/Information Experience Design

I was initially torn between Communication Design and Industrial Design.

Communication Design attracted me because it was the field I was first exposed to—creating logos, designing layouts for soft boards in school, and making visually appealing school projects. My limited knowledge pushed me towards Communication Design at first. However, I soon realized that Industrial Design offered the perfect blend for me. It allowed me to explore both physical and digital product development while combining research and engaging with people, which I enjoy.

Over time, I discovered that Interaction Design isn't just about making things look good. It's about making them feel right and work intuitively, grounded in a deep understanding of people's needs.

Interaction Design lies at the intersection of technology, psychology, and design, enabling you to solve problems, push boundaries, and create meaningful experiences—without being restricted to one discipline.

INTERNSHIPS AND PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Q2. In your most recent internship or experience (or your longest internship/experience), what is the biggest learning you have had (150 words maximum)

Guidelines to answer

- Do not copy paste from CV
 - Mention the name of the company and period that you're referring to
 - Try to think of a couple of incidents for this
 - Provide unique learnings that are relevant to your field and/or any achievements that you had from this
 - Discuss tools/techniques/processes that were used or needed for these
-
- The biggest learning I've had is that user experience comes first, followed by user interface design. The experience a digital product should provide to the user must be defined first before jumping into designing the product itself.
 - The rules that define what the user wants from the product and what will make it easiest for them to use should be prioritized. For example, deciding which features should be front and center or finding ways to reduce the time it takes for users to complete a task.
 - When I started my job, I would jump straight into designing a product after the first interaction with the client. However, I later realized the importance of understanding the requirements in depth, not just at a surface level. This is a habit many designers likely have too.
 - The habit in the UI design industry is that "what looks pretty sells the fastest" was proven wrong through experience. Additionally, this approach saves time, as understanding the

consumer's requirements from the start leads to fewer revisions and a more direct path to the right solution.

- Hence, Users defined experience is the first step which is followed by Designing the interface.

Q3. Summarize earlier/other internships/experiences (150 words maximum)

If you have pursued more than 2 internships and experiences, we will not have space to mention each and every one in the SOP. Anyway, details of most of these are covered in the CV. Use this question to highlight learnings or motivations or triggers that you had for your career.

(Answered this question in Q1B under service design) - Still adding more points

1. For my final graduation project, I worked for 6 months in a village in Assam under a company's "Corporate Social Responsibility" programme. This experience taught me a great deal. Since I was working alone without a team, the first thing I learned was how to multitask. Managing an industry-level project solo involved handling research, analysis, design, brainstorming, project management, and more. I quickly adapted to handling large projects independently.

Additionally, working with the local villagers presented a key challenge: communication. Whether during research or product development, clear communication was essential. To overcome this, I developed methods such as using flashcards during research, translated interview sheets, and creating rapid mock-ups to help artisans visualize the product in 3D. These challenges taught me various research techniques and how to practice design while immersed in the field.

2. In one of my internships, I also worked on projects outside my core learning, such as rebranding and graphic design. Though not part of my formal education, it increased my flexibility and taught me new skills and software, making me realize the importance of saying yes to new types of projects and challenges which only be beneficial in the future.

Q4. Is there any family business/start-up that you have? If yes, what is the scope of the business/start-up and how have you been involved with it? (150 words maximum)

Guidelines to answer

- You can skip this question if you are currently working at the start-up or family business (and have covered the details in Q3)
- Showing entrepreneurial skills/independence is strongly recommended
- For a start-up – show how much it has scaled, how many people are involved, whether you are a sole founder or do you have co-founders etc.

NA

ACADEMICS AND COLLEGE ACTIVITIES

Q5. Favourite Subjects and Scores, Tools and Techniques (75 words maximum)

- Mention 2-4 subjects related to the field we are applying for
 - Also give details about certifications such as CA, CFA etc. or tools/languages such as C, C++, Java, Bloomberg Capital Markets etc. that you have learnt
1. My favorite course in college was **Systems Design** (GPA - 9.2). The approach to design that it taught was extremely interesting. It emphasized looking at a problem area holistically before identifying an intervention. This means considering all stakeholders, touchpoints, and environments associated with the problem, which can reveal a more impactful intervention area and help determine the most suitable intervention type.
 2. A similar approach was applied in the courses on **Service Design** (GPA - 8.9) and **Interaction Design** (GPA - 9.8), but in the context of digital and technological solutions.

These courses focused on how a problem can be solved through digital interventions by merging technology with design.

Q6. Key Academic Projects (max 3) including final year project (100 words maximum each)

Guidelines to answer

- Mention the name of the project and period that you're referring to; Discuss the scope and main challenge of the project
- Provide unique learnings that are relevant to your field
- Discuss tools/techniques/processes that were used or needed for the project

1. Apunar Japi – translates to "Our Japi" in Assamese (Final Year Project) – 6 months

The project aimed to collaborate with local artisans in Nalbari, Assam, skilled in traditional bamboo weaving techniques, to create two interior product ranges with high perceived value, helping artisans increase their income. Additionally, I trained over 25 women from the artisan village on how to improve the marketability of the products. The main challenge was building trust with the villagers, especially since I didn't speak their language and looked different from them. I overcame this by spending hours each day with the villagers, dressing like them, and learning their language. The key learning from this project was how to adjust to new situations. Tools used included Kevin Lynch's mapping techniques, craft process documentation, data analysis, rapid prototyping, and diverse ideation.

2. STI Management amongst Female Sex Workers of Bhopal – (Last Semester Project) – 8 weeks

This project analyzed STI management practices, awareness levels, and barriers restricting access to services among female sex workers (FSWs) in Bhopal. It involved examining the roles of various stakeholders and the effectiveness of local support systems. The biggest challenge was identifying sex workers due to the secrecy surrounding their profession. Using snowball sampling, we were able to locate them. The second challenge was gaining their trust, as they feared authorities like the police. Given the research-heavy nature of the project, we identified various pain points using methods like GIGA mapping, user journeys, and iceberg models to understand the data. Additionally, we invented our own data analysis and visualization model, the "Trigger and Response Model," to interpret findings more effectively.

3. Redesigning Construction Barricades – (Last Semester Project) – 6 weeks

The project aimed to redesign construction barricades to enhance public safety in busy roads and areas. The goal was to make barricades more visible and safer for pedestrians while improving factors like ease of installation, maintenance, and storage for other stakeholders. This would ultimately increase the barricades' overall safety, security, and longevity. We conducted behavioral mapping and studied various stakeholders, including workers who install the barricades, as well as drivers of cars and rickshaws, to understand their challenges and requirements. The primary challenge was addressing the diverse group of stakeholders involved: those who build the barricades, direct users, and numerous indirect users. Additionally, we created a full-scale prototype using actual materials and tested it with key stakeholders, incorporating feedback for a second round of revisions.

Q7. Extra-Curricular and/or Co-curricular Activities (100 words maximum)

Guidelines to Answer

- Pick 1 or 2 key activities that you have done – idea here is not to list things you have done but to explain the personality/mind behind the activities
- Mention the name of the activity and period that you're referring to; Discuss the scope and main challenge of the activity
- How did the activity help you grow (personally or professionally) and/or why is the activity important for you (learning)?
- If you have a research paper published, mention the motivation behind the paper

1. Research Paper - 'International Conference on Research into Design' (ICoRD'25) - Research Paper Selection under Department of Design - IIT Hyderabad | 2025

(This paper is selected for the conference but has not been published yet.)

This study explores the psychological effects of touch on self-identity, focusing on trauma and personality development. Through semi-structured interviews and visual representations (n=15), we identified the influence of gender biases, societal norms, and educational gaps in childhood responses to touch. Based on these findings, we designed an educational activity kit for children (ages 8-13) to teach boundaries and emotional responses, aiming to promote healthy conversations and early education about touch. The kit included collaborative exercises, a board game, and other interactive elements. The paper offers a unique understanding of "grey touches," an under-explored topic, and provides a direct intervention for an age group that is rarely addressed. This research deepened my understanding of the importance of consolidating research and how a well-constructed paper can lead to future developments and interventions in identified problem areas.

2. Theatre

During college, I participated in several stage programs and even anchored events. However, theatre was a completely new way for me to engage with an audience. I performed the lead role in front of 250-300 people during a fest, after going through auditions. Being selected boosted my confidence. Additionally, I contributed creatively by helping design the set. This experience taught me the value of trying new things and trusting my instincts when faced with challenges.

Q8 – Is there any outstanding achievement that you have that can be a core of your personality? If yes explain the same with history of involvement, key milestones and future plans for this (100 words maximum)

Examples of Activities that can be considered

- Sports Achievement – Olympics, Asian Games, World Tournaments, India/State representative
- Industry Level/National/International Academic/Professional Award
- Participation/winning challenges such as Peter Drucker Challenge, Ace Manager, Holt Valuation Challenge, International Challenge on Economic Ideas, Shell Ideas 360 etc.
- **Do not put** committee involvement unless the committee has a huge budget (1 Cr+)

1. Topper in College - Highest Cumulative Grade Points in All Semesters

As a child, I struggled with self-confidence and self-worth, influenced by various childhood and school experiences. I vividly remember my first month at NID, where the faculty explained the strict grading system and the high standards expected. While I understood that design, being subjective, can't always follow traditional grading methods, it still frightened me. With my existing self-doubts, I feared I might not belong or even pass. This fear drove me to put extra effort into every course, hoping my best would be enough. As semesters passed, I focused on

the process, not the outcome. When I was recognized as the topper, it reminded me that I am worthy and capable. This achievement was a crucial step in building my self-confidence.

FUTURE GOALS

Q9. Describe your short term and long-term goals (150 words maximum)

Guidelines to Answer

- Please do not mention your goal is to 'Get a Master's Degree'. This question refers to your goals after the Master's degree
- Provide details of types of companies/countries/fields you would want to work in
- Try to link your current experience with the future goals
- Can also focus on a trend/challenge you want to solve/work on

Short-term goal

Lately, I've had the opportunity to share my design experiences with many juniors and other aspiring designers through my coaching center and college. This opportunity to teach and share my experiences through my projects has sparked a desire to continue sharing them as I grow. I hope to inspire other such designers who can potentially learn even a little from my experiences. While this could eventually evolve into a full-time career, for now, it remains a short-term goal that I aim to pursue and expand upon in the near future.

Long-term goal

Although how I want to achieve my goal is not yet fully defined, I know I want to focus on identifying impactful problem areas that can benefit larger social groups, rather than just small organizations. In past experiences, such as working with female sex workers, transgenders, artisans, and victims of bad touch, amongst many I have found immense fulfillment in applying my design skills to causes that matter and social groups that need help. My personal interests for public speaking, meeting new people, traveling and photography and meeting new cultures complements my professional ethics as a designer as well as mentioned above. Lastly, I would like to work with organizations like Hindustan Unilever who work on grounded projects with a lot of time on the field working with unthought of social communities.

STATEMENT OF INTENT

Amongst stalwarts of user-centered design, the person who inspires me most is Steve Krug. His seminal work, *Don't Make Me Think*, a book on web usability, has profoundly shaped my understanding of design. Krug is radical, emphasizing function over aesthetics and advocating for self-evident designs that prioritize user experience above all else. What I read this as is that good design should simplify, not complicate. Krug does this by focusing on clear visual hierarchies and ensuring navigation serves its purpose. I have adapted this idea to my work, believing that a product's experience holds more value and precedence over the visual interface. Like all novice designers, I too initially focused on surface-level requirements, jumping straight into creating the best aesthetic designs possible. But over time, through practice and feedback (and some humbling mistakes!), I realized the importance of going to the root of user needs, reducing fluff, and making designs that embody clarity—an approach Krug champions.

I was searching for like-minded professionals who shared this philosophy and have been fortunate to work with Mr. Sudhir Bhatia, the founder of BRND—my current studio. His emphasis on experience-driven design has reiterated that a design is like a well-oiled machine; although at times unpleasant to the eye from the outside, it works as smoothly as butter on the inside, fulfilling its intrinsic purpose. Working with him has allowed me to stay true to these principles, reaffirming that thoughtful, user-centered design is at the heart of innovation.

While I do not have an absolute favorite, Krug's teachings and Bhatia's mentorship have made a significant impact on my personal values and design ethos. By studying their work and integrating their techniques into my design process, I hope to create functional and intuitive products and services.

I envision the future designer Rachit, working on ideas that blend strategy, design, and technology, becoming an expert in human-centric design by creating versatile design solutions that have high utility, speak to the audience, and help achieve the underlying business objectives. My collaboration with bamboo artisans in Assam, to help promote the endangered Japi craft, has shown me how design can breathe new life into traditional art forms. In the future, I see myself creating modular, self-sustaining products and services like furniture with IoT sensors to monitor air quality or crosswalks that adjust automatically to ensure the safety of pedestrians during peak hours. Although this may sound utopian, with the right mix of practicality and technology, it can become a blueprint for a better future.

In preparation for such a lofty career progression, I have earned a bachelor's degree from India's premier design school, the National Institute of Design (NID). I have worked on innovative projects like redesigning construction barricades, creating an educational activity kit to teach children about personal boundaries, developing a mechanical tool for flower vendors, and promoting a dying indigenous bamboo art form from Assam. I have also challenged myself by undertaking industry internships to learn the real-world applicability of my studies. At Thinkonomers (HDL), I learned to apply user feedback in the design process; my work with Pichkaari Design Studio revolved around rebranding projects and developing user flow enhancement prototypes; at Grant Thornton, I undertook a community-driven design project to revive endangered Japi craft of Assam; and finally, in my current role as a UX/UI designer at BRND Studio, I handle end-to-end design for SaaS dashboards, educational platforms, and teaching tools.

In addition to my academic and professional pursuits, I have actively participated in various extracurricular activities that have refined my teamwork and leadership and given me a well-rounded skill set that I believe will enable me to perform at my best during my master's.

It has been an incredible journey these past few years, and I am now excited to savor every experience of graduate life, whether it is the rigorous course curriculum, access to the SVA alumni network, or the prospect of living in NYC. As an independent individual, I would appreciate your feedback on my candidacy and kindly request you to consider any merit-based scholarship that may be available. It would not only ease my financial situation but also allow me to fully devote myself to my studies and actively contribute to the university community. I bring with me a diverse set of experiences, skills, and perspectives that I believe would greatly enrich the SVA's student body. I am deeply passionate about learning, committed to academic excellence, and eager to make a positive impact both inside and outside the classroom.

Personal video introduction link:

https://drive.google.com/file/d/1fBBcfq1tEVzGDXby3CBYSRRyFFgvB5GO/view?usp=drive_link

STATEMENT OF PURPOSE - 01

How have your prior activities and experiences (e.g., things you have done at school, in the workplace, in your community, and/or extracurricular activities) prepared you for this program and this field? Please provide specific examples. [600 words maximum]

Growing up in Bangalore, life unfolded in straight lines and stark edges, where every structure was a servant of purpose, and aesthetics took a backseat to utility. It wasn't until I wandered through the vibrant streets of Barcelona, for a trip during high school, that I discovered the quiet poetry of aesthetics in public spaces. This revelation stirred a deep admiration within me during those early years. My ensuing creative practice has been shaped by my undergraduate studies in Industrial Design and diverse professional experiences. In this time, I have explored the design process in areas like innovative product development, user-centric methodologies, and systems thinking. This ability to use scientific advancements to create new products and services that drive business and the economy while making people's lives easier and more comfortable excites and motivates me to build a long-term career in this field.

I pursued my Bachelor's degree from India's premier design school, the National Institute of Design (NID), where my design thinking and creativity took a decisively humane and people-oriented direction. During my time at NID, I was introduced to three facets of design: systems design, service design, and interaction design. The systems approach taught me to look at a problem area in its entirety before identifying potential interventions, while interaction design focused on technological interventions. But service design appealed to me the most due to its ability to solve problems through user-centricity and accessible designs.

In college, I took on multiple design assignments that further helped me identify my design niche. For my graduation assignment with Grant Thornton, I worked with indigenous bamboo artisans from Assam to revive endangered Japi crafts and saw firsthand how design had the unique power to effect social change. For a similar project, by using a participatory design approach, I designed a mechanical tool that alleviated the physical strain and increased the productivity of flower vendors engaged in garland-weaving activities. I also used behavioral mapping to understand the challenges faced by pedestrians and drivers and designed a lightweight, highly visible construction barricade to improve safety for pedestrians during peak traffic hours.

Beyond these community-based projects, I worked on two tech-intensive projects. In the first, I analyzed STI management practices and barriers restricting access to services among female sex workers (FSWs) in Bhopal. Employing snowball sampling techniques to locate their work zones and, using methods like GIGA mapping user journeys, I developed a Trigger and Response Model to better interpret the data. The project led to recommendations for community-centric support systems such as mobile clinics and awareness programs. In the second project, I created an educational activity kit to help children explore self-identity. By utilizing user journey mapping, participatory testing, and iterative prototyping, I built a tool to help children understand and express their feelings, which was later presented and published at the International Conference on Research into Design (ICoRD'25).

My myriad set of formative learnings has coalesced into my passion for making a career in human-centered design and user experience research. I have come to appreciate that product design, albeit a creative process, requires conversance with software design tools, user-centric methodologies, and an allied understanding of socio-economic dynamics and business management to truly understand the consumer ask. While I have been working on developing the aforementioned proficiencies, I require advanced training and international exposure to the field, which I hope to gain through the MS Human Centered Design & Engineering program at the University of Washington.

STATEMENT OF PURPOSE - 02

Please describe your particular interest in Human Centered Design & Engineering, and explain what specific elements of the program make it a good fit for you. How will this program assist you in your longer-term goals? Please provide specific examples. [600 words maximum]

I have explored the design process in areas like innovative product development, user-centric methodologies, and systems thinking. This ability to use scientific advancements to create new products and services that drive business and the economy and, at the same time, make people's lives easier and more comfortable is something that excites and motivates me to build a long-term career in this field. I now wish to augment my portfolio and train my design thinking mindset to scope, refine, and deliver practicable solutions and translate abstract ideas, theories, and plans into practice through an MS in Human-Centered Design & Engineering (HCDE).

After completing my graduate studies, I aim to work as a User Experience (UX) Researcher or Innovation Strategist with creative firms such as Accenture, Publicis Sapien, or Google. I am passionate about working on service ecosystems that address critical challenges in accessibility, equity, and inclusion for underserved populations. For example, I want to design services for marginalized communities, such as affordable healthcare frameworks or digital platforms for skilling and business training for rural and tribal artisans. These goals are inspired by my earlier project in Assam, where I worked with artisans to develop community-driven solutions. Additionally, I am open to contributing to digital products like fintech solutions or interactive educational platforms, using my design background to create user-friendly, impactful tools. My long-term vision is to become an expert in human-centric design by creating versatile design solutions that have high utility, speak to the audience, and help achieve the underlying business objectives. UX research has the potential to understand the undercurrent of consumer's needs—not just what they say they need—and to translate these ideas into tangible solutions. I also want to work in innovation strategy, as it will enable me to zoom out the lens on entire ecosystems and design solutions for long-term, sustainable impact.

The Human Centered Design & Engineering program at the University of Washington offers the ideal environment for me to cultivate my skills and achieve these goals. I am particularly drawn to the Accessibility and Inclusive Design and Usability Studies modules, which emphasize design thinking and the practical application of industry-relevant tools. With my previous work to uplift marginalized communities and promote heritage, the course on Designing Inclusive Interactions will be especially useful to enhance my understanding of building equitable, user-focused systems catering especially to those with disabilities or limited resources.

Along with this in-class learning, the University of Washington is also renowned for its research-integrated teaching practice. Given my interest in creating affordable healthcare frameworks, I am especially keen to explore HCDE Design Use Build (DUB) Group's projects on accessibility, civic technology, and sustainability-based digital tools and interfaces. The program's emphasis on experiential learning through industry collaborations, live projects, and its state-of-the-art Makeability Lab, The Momentary Experience Lab, and Inclusive Design Lab excites me as they provide an opportunity to experiment with emerging technologies such as IoT or AR/VR. Moreover, the University of Washington's collaborative atmosphere, which includes industry events, HCDE's annual Open House, and Capstone Showcases, will provide opportunities to engage with like-minded peers and professionals and the platform to present my work to the industry at large.

Last but not least, I was happy to discover The Taskar Center for Accessible Technology, whose focus on inclusive technology design and development mirrors my mission to develop products and services that address socio-economic inequities and improve overall quality of life.

By making full use of these and the numerous other opportunities on campus, I do not doubt that I will become an industry-ready professional, possessing the skills I need to achieve my goals.

STATEMENT OF PURPOSE

Growing up in Bangalore, life unfolded in straight lines and stark edges, where every structure was a servant of purpose, and aesthetics took a backseat to utility. It wasn't until I wandered through the vibrant streets of Barcelona for a trip during high school that I discovered the quiet poetry of aesthetics in public spaces. This revelation stirred a deep admiration within me during those early years. My ensuing creative practice has been shaped by my undergraduate studies in Industrial Design and diverse professional experiences

As I took on curricular assignments to apply classroom theories in real-time practice, I gradually identified my design niche. For my graduation assignment with Grant Thornton, I worked with indigenous bamboo artisans from Assam to revive endangered Japi crafts and saw firsthand how design had the unique power to effect social change. For a similar project, by using a participatory design approach, I designed a mechanical tool that alleviated the physical strain and increased the productivity of flower vendors engaged in garland weaving activities. I also used behavioral mapping to understand the challenges faced by pedestrians and drivers and designed a lightweight, highly visible construction barricade to improve safety for pedestrians during peak traffic hours.

Beyond these community-based projects, I worked on two tech-intensive projects. In the first, I analyzed STI management practices and barriers restricting access to services among female sex workers (FSWs) in Bhopal. Employing snowball sampling techniques to locate their work zones and, using methods like GIGA mapping user journeys, I developed a Trigger and Response Model to better interpret the data. The project led to recommendations for community-centric support systems such as mobile clinics and awareness programs. In the second project, I created an educational activity kit to help children explore self-identity. By utilizing user journey mapping, participatory testing, and iterative prototyping, I built a tool to help children understand and express their feelings, which was later presented and published at the International Conference on Research into Design (ICoRD'25).

From a bird's-eye perspective, all my projects have reiterated the interconnection of design, utility, and sustainability. This understanding has been further strengthened through my professional experiences—at Thinkonomers (HDL), where I learned about the importance of user feedback in the design process, at Pichkaari Design Studio, where I worked on rebranding projects and developed user flow enhancement prototypes, Grant Thornton, and finally in my current role as a UX/UI designer at BRND Studio, where I handle end-to-end design for SaaS dashboards, educational platforms, and teaching tools. These experiences have ingrained in me that user experience should be the top priority in the design process and helped shape my design philosophy, which is based on creating superlative, easy-to-use experiences for modern spaces, both virtual and real. For example, in my initial projects, I dove headfirst into design but with experience and trial and error, I realized that logic in design will hold little value unless it is thoughtfully integrated with an intuitive understanding of how it will be used by humans.

Collectively, these five years of formative learning have coalesced into my chosen career path in Service Design. After graduate studies, I plan to work as a Service Designer or Innovation Strategist with creative firms like Adobe or Deloitte, on projects that blend strategy, design, and technology. I am passionate about working on service ecosystems that address critical challenges in accessibility, equity, and inclusion for underserved populations. For example, I want to design services for marginalized communities, such as affordable healthcare frameworks or digital platforms for skilling and business training for rural and tribal artisans. These goals are inspired by my earlier project in Assam, where I worked with artisans to develop community-driven solutions. Additionally, I am open

to contributing to digital products like fintech solutions or interactive educational platforms, using my design background to create user-friendly, impactful tools. My long-term vision is to become an expert in human-centric design by creating versatile design solutions that have high utility, speak to the audience, and help achieve the underlying business objectives.

I have come to appreciate that product design, albeit a creative process, requires conversance with software design tools, user-centric methodologies, and an allied understanding of socio-economic dynamics and business management to truly understand the consumer's question. While I have been working on developing the aforementioned proficiencies, I require advanced training and international exposure to the field, which I hope to gain through the MA in Service Design at SCAD.

SVA - Statement of Purpose

1. Personal written statement: We want to know how critical and creative thinking shapes your design work and other pursuits. Please answer the following questions in 500-700 words:

- 1. Tell us about someone you look up to and why. The person can be a designer, a friend, a relative, someone in your neighborhood—anyone who inspires you and your creative practice.**
- 2. Imagine it is 20 years from the present moment. Describe your life—what kind of work are you engaging in, what are your home and community like, in what ways have you shaped the field of interaction design, and how has the field of interaction design shaped your life?**
- 3. MFA Interaction Design offers modest, merit-based scholarships. Please indicate in your essay if you would like to be considered for a merit-based departmental award.**

Please submit this as a PDF document.

750 words maximum.

Q1. Tell us about someone you look up to and why. The person can be a designer, a friend, a relative, someone in your neighborhood—anyone who inspires you and your creative practice.

The person who inspires me is Steve Krug, the author of *Don't Make Me Think*, a seminal book on web usability that shaped my understanding of design. His principles emphasize function over aesthetics, advocating for intuitive, self-evident designs that prioritize user experience above all else. From creating clear visual hierarchies to ensuring navigation serves its purpose, Krug's approach resonated deeply with my belief that a product's experience must come first, followed by its interface. Early in my career, I used to focus on surface-level requirements, jumping straight into designs. Over time, I realized the value of digging deeper into user needs, reducing unnecessary complexity, and designing with clarity—an approach Krug champions. I was searching for like-minded professionals who shared this philosophy when I came across Sudhir Bhatia, the founder of my current studio. His emphasis on experience-driven design reinforced my confidence that not everything is about making things look pretty—it's about making them work. Working with him has inspired me to stay true to these principles, reaffirming that thoughtful, user-centered design is the foundation of impactful work.

Q2. Imagine it is 20 years from the present moment. Describe your life—what kind of work are you engaging in, what are your home and community like, in what ways have you shaped the field of interaction design, and how has the field of interaction design shaped your life?

As an interaction designer, I'm passionate about creating solutions that make a real difference, especially for communities that struggle to fully benefit from today's rapidly evolving technology. My work has always been about finding impactful problem areas and addressing them in a way that empowers people and creates lasting change. Over the years, I've had the chance to work with diverse groups, from female sex workers and transgender individuals to artisans and survivors of abuse. These experiences have taught me how powerful design can be in bridging gaps and helping people improve their lives.

I'm also driven by my love for public speaking, meeting new people, traveling, and exploring different cultures. These personal interests fuel my professional work, helping me better understand the unique challenges faced by various communities

Q3.MFA Interaction Design offers modest, merit-based scholarships. Please indicate in your essay if you would like to be considered for a merit-based departmental award.

I would like to be, but I am unsure how to respond to in the SOP

MASTER SOP.

Growing up in Bangalore, life unfolded in straight lines and stark edges, where every structure was a servant of purpose, and aesthetics took a backseat to utility. It wasn't until I wandered through the vibrant streets of Barcelona, for a trip during high school, that I discovered the quiet poetry of aesthetics in public spaces. This revelation stirred a deep admiration within me during those early years. My undergraduate studies in Industrial Design and diverse professional experiences have shaped my ensuing creative practice. During this time, I have explored the design process in areas like innovative product development, user-centric methodologies, and systems thinking. This ability to use scientific advancements to create new products and services that drive business and economy while making people's lives easier and more comfortable excites and motivates me to build a long-term career in this field. I now wish to augment my portfolio and train my design thinking mindset to scope, refine, and deliver practicable solutions and translate abstract ideas, theories, and plans into practice through an MFA Interaction Design

This academic goal is a well-thought-out progression of my interests and skillset. I have always loved arts and crafts as a young boy and knew that I wanted to work in a field that would allow me to express my creativity and challenge me intellectually. My Bachelor's degree from India's premier design school National Institute of Design (NID), has given my design thought, creativity, and critical thinking a decisively humane and people-oriented direction. It introduced me to three facets of design: systems design, service design, and interaction design – each with its unique applications that called for deeper exploration. The systems approach calls for looking at a problem area holistically before identifying an intervention type, service design relies on solving design problems with the aid of techno-digital interventions, whereas interaction designs shed light on making such designs more user-centric.

From developing a mechanical tool for garland weaving that improved the efficiency and comfort of flower vendors to creating an educational activity kit exploring self-identity for children, (the latter is selected for presentation and publication at the International Conference on Research into Design - ICoRD'25), all my projects have reiterated the interconnection of design, community, and sustainability.

Collectively, these five years of formative learning have coalesced into my chosen career path in MFA Interaction Design. After graduate studies, I plan to work on projects that blend strategy, design, and technology as a UX Researcher or Innovation Strategist with creative firms like Google or Logitech Inc.. Specifically, I aim to work on service ecosystems that address pressing socio-economic inequities by co-creating accessible services for marginalized communities—such as affordable healthcare frameworks or skill-building digital platforms for rural artisans, inspired by my earlier work in Assam. I am also open to working on digital products like fintech solutions or interactive educational platforms. My long-term vision is to become an expert in human-centric design by creating versatile design solutions that have high utility, speak to the audience, and help achieve the underlying business objectives.

The **Information Experience Design** program at SVA is the perfect conduit to materialize these. I am particularly interested in the Service Design, Inclusive Design, and Designing for Digital Accessibility modules which encourage design thinking and conversance with industry-relevant tools. SVA's emphasis on practical learning through industry collaborations and live projects, and its state-of-the-art The Visible Futures Lab provide an ideal environment for me to experiment with emerging technologies such as xxx. I am excited to collaborate with the intellectually spirited student cohort for Dream Spaces and engage in team-based innovation to devise solutions for contemporary social and environmental challenges. By making full use of these and the numerous other opportunities on campus, I do not doubt that I will become an industry-ready professional, possessing the skills I need to achieve my goals.

SVA - Video Script

Personal video introduction: We want to know *who* you are and *why* you are choosing to apply to the MFA ixD program. We invited you to share your unique personality with us in your video. Record a video introduction answering the following:

- What excites you about the field of interaction design at this moment in your life?
- What does interaction design mean to you?
- We invite you to share your unique personality with us in your video.
- video must be submitted as a URL
- 90 seconds maximum
- Please add the URL of the video to your written statement.

I'm Rachit Singhi, an industrial designer with a passion for creating thoughtful, impactful design experiences and solutions.

Q1. What excites you about the field of interaction design at this moment in your life?

With the ever-changing and evolving technology, I see a lot of opportunities to help technology reach communities that have very little access to it because of a lack of knowledge on how to maximize its benefits. What excites me most about the field of interaction design right now is its incredible potential to bridge the gap between cutting-edge technology and underserved communities. Technology is evolving at a rapid pace, but many people remain excluded from its benefits simply because of limited access or a lack of understanding of how to use it effectively. As an interaction designer, I see an opportunity to create intuitive, inclusive, and accessible designs that empower these communities to engage with technology meaningfully.

Q2. What does interaction design mean to you?

Interaction design means problem-solving that blends strategy, design, and technology in a way that makes interactions with services much simpler, easier, and quicker. Ultimately, interaction design is the process of transforming challenges into opportunities by leveraging technology and design to create experiences that feel natural, easy, and impactful for the user.

Can bring more info from the previous scripts?

Video task advice

We would like you to submit a 2-3 minute video to help us learn more about you. When recording your task, please face the camera and speak in English.

What to include in your video task

- Choose 1 project from your portfolio and explain how it challenged you and your understanding of service design.
- Tell us how this experience inspired you to apply for the MA in Service Design at the London College of Communication.

Script:

I am Rachit Singhi, a user-centered industrial designer passionate about creating thoughtful, impactful design experiences and solutions. With the same motive in mind, I undertook a project as a summer trainee with Grant Thornton Bharat, a corporation that provides services to business sectors such as accounting and auditing.

This project gave me insight into an industry that I wouldn't have conventionally considered, solely because of the internship opportunity I had gotten. I had the chance to work in the organization as a designer for my graduation project. I collaborated with the bamboo artisans of Assam for six months, developing novel product ranges as part of their Corporate Social Responsibility Programme.

During this project, I realized the importance of service design in any industry and how the lack of the right smart work could overshadow the results of hard work, and Grant Thornton, in my personal opinion, did lack here. Grant Thornton is an Indian organization that has major collaborations with the government to become the leading firm in the auditing and accounting sector from India, replacing other multinational corporations whose base doesn't stem from India to make the country self-reliant.

On interacting with a few employees of the organization, it was realized that the organization is hiring employees who have worked in the Big 4 earlier, providing them with a better scale with the motive of being able to compete with these challenging firms through experienced employees. However, this limits the number of employees the organization can hire due to the increased pay to be given to them and, as a response, increases the workload among these limited employees. Additionally, these employees are experienced in dealing with large public sector entities and organizations like Fortune 500 companies, which have a well-defined structure of roles and responsibilities. On the other hand, Grant Thornton is still a growing organization dealing with mid-sized businesses and government entities, where there are well-defined departments, but the division of work isn't balanced, hindering the overall journey of a customer and user.

While the organization is making an effort, what Grant Thornton has not recognized is that the competing organizations have a defined brand perception and market positioning with a global reach and scale that have been developed and built over the years. Replicating a model from an already established organization might not prove to be as effective, and identifying new and unique problem

areas novel to the organization would prove a lot more effective in its success and in employee and client retention. Due to issues like these, initiatives like CSR, which can help in brand positioning in the competitive market, also suffer majorly, with no proper framework in place for smooth productivity to take place.

This experience deeply challenged my understanding of service design by revealing how crucial it is to have a well-thought-out framework in place to ensure both employee well-being and customer satisfaction. I saw firsthand how the lack of a balanced, user-centered approach can undermine even the most promising initiatives, such as CSR, preventing them from reaching their full potential. Being part of a growing organization like Grant Thornton allowed me to witness the struggles of adapting service design principles in an environment still defining its identity and workflows. These challenges pushed me to think more critically and creatively about how design can solve systemic inefficiencies. It was this realization that inspired me to pursue the Service Design course, as I want to develop the skills and knowledge to design solutions that drive meaningful and lasting impact.

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Script:

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One such service the organization works on involves collaborating with multiple rural sector stakeholders as part of its corporate social responsibility program. I had the opportunity to work at the organization as a designer for my graduation project, where I collaborated with the bamboo artisans of Assam for six months, understanding their craft techniques and developing two product ranges that appealed to the current market, thereby increasing the income levels of the artisans.

While the project seemed impactful on the surface—given that the organization defined the required output beforehand to create a greater good for the artisans—I quickly realized the number of loopholes that existed in the pre-defined output. These issues indicated a lack of research and an inadequate understanding of how the problem needed to be solved by meeting the requirements of the artisans from the project.

I understand and realize that CSRs and rural development aren't the primary goals of Grant Thornton and hence, it isn't the mistake of the organization for the loopholes to exist because of the limited resources available for such initiatives to be taken to their full capacity. Still, the project helped me have a personal realization of the importance of service design.

Considering I wasn't the first to conduct such training with the artisans, it raised an important question: Why had previous training sessions not been effective? This question opened up a can of worms, allowing me to examine the entire project holistically. I began questioning whether simply having an output that the organization thinks is impactful was enough or if it was far more important to consider how to deliver the output to maximize its impact, considering what the key stakeholders are looking for from such interventions and training.

This project became a lens through which I understood the importance of service design. It highlighted the importance of not coming up with a solution for the identified problem area until proper research has been undertaken with the primary players involved in the ecosystem. This project highlighted the idea that just having a particular solution isn't sufficient; rather, how the intervention is delivered can make all the difference in achieving a meaningful impact that sticks and is applied in a real-world scenario.

For instance, in this scenario, the training conducted in the past disconnected the artisans from their culture, teaching them techniques that were unfamiliar and introducing products without adequately explaining how to market these newer products through novel marketing channels. These drawbacks and other similar issues highlight the importance of appropriate and multi-faceted solutions.

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Considering I wasn't the first to conduct such training with the artisans, it raised an important question: Why had previous training sessions not been effective? This question opened up a can of worms, allowing me to examine the entire project a lot more holistically. I began questioning whether simply having an output that the organization thinks is impactful was enough or if it was far more important to consider how to deliver the output to maximize its impact, keeping in mind what the key stakeholders are looking for from such interventions and training.

This project became a lens through which I understood the importance of service design. The importance of not coming up with a solution for the identified problem area until proper research has been undertaken with the primary players involved in the ecosystem. This project highlighted the idea that just having a particular solution isn't sufficient; rather, the way the intervention is delivered can make all the difference in achieving a meaningful impact that sticks and is applied in a real-world scenario.

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About yourself - Don't talk about your qualities, mention extracurricular activities
Rachit singhi, I have pursued industrial design from NID, currently working as a UX/UI designer, And i believe I have the ability to identify the right intervention area, and opportunity areas, empathize with the users. I have a keen interest in public speaking and i find ways to express my opinion for example teaching the juniors as a mentor or doing theatre.

Strengths weakness - have examples ready

3 strengths, 2 weaknesses

Strength

1. I am process driven, and hence my strength is reaching to logical solutions and identify appropriate loop holes and ways to deliver a solution. Example working with grant thornton
2. An appropriate opportunity area
3. Leadership and allocating work or next steps

Weakness

1. Micromanage
2. Time management and process driven example not an apt solution

Situation questions- star format

1. Situation, task, action and result

20% should be the situation and task - the background

The action will be 50%

Result will be the learning

MENTION HOW YOU LEAD THE TEAM - I miss reallocated as a leader

A project in studio, over ambitious and overpromised, and i'd make them overwork
Project was increasing footfall and reducing drop offs throughout the process, a part of that was understanding

Short term long term - straight from the sop

- Gain exposure to industry-relevant tools and methodologies, particularly in accessibility and inclusive design, usability studies, and equitable systems design.
- Enhance the ability to translate abstract ideas and plans into practical, user-focused solutions.

Long term goal -

- IDEO, or Deloitte Digital, on
- projects that blend strategy, design, and technology.
User experience designer or Innovation Strategist
 - Empower users, larger societal impacts
 - Technology and design are evolving at breakneck speed
 - Cater to diverse populations
 - Unserved populations and empower them

Why this college - do the research and understand the process if clubs and stuff

- larger system-level projects in multidisciplinary teams and experimental methodologies for addressing futures (Design for futures)
- Collaborative unit - I love multidisciplinary projects
- Work on industry projects
- Service futures lab - Very community-driven projects that resonate with what drives me as a designer too. My past projects resonate with it as well

Why now? As a student in the recent past ,i might be able to learn more now
Masters was also in the list - i wanted to understand and research a lot more and learn

Questions -

1. How do you answer the question take me through your interview

INTRODUCTORY QUESTIONS: Generally, these are the opening questions asked by the interview panel.

Q1. Tell us something about yourself or Walk me through your resume/profile

Q2. How would your friends/family/colleagues/supervisor describe you?

Q3. Introduce yourself to your classmates

Hi, I am Rachit Singhi. I have pursued my bachelor's degree in industrial design from the National Institute of Design. Currently I work as a UI/UX designer, that is, a user interface and user experience designer. I believe my greatest strengths are my ability to empathize with people fairly easily, develop user-centered designs, and recognize the opportunity and intervention areas that will have the biggest effects on the user. Apart from my professional interests, I am also keen on public speaking, and I love finding ways to be in front of an audience or express my opinion, for example, repeatedly mentoring my juniors from college on various projects, showcasing my projects, or even doing theatre when I find the opportunity.

Tips

Focus on the CV that you have submitted & balance between personal & professional description

Only Open topics that you want the interviewer to go into further detail

Do not exceed 120 seconds in the answer

FACT EVALUATION QUESTIONS: Aimed at understanding your interpersonal skills by discussing actual life events

Q1. What are your greatest strengths and weaknesses?

I would like to highlight and talk about 3 of my strengths and 2 weaknesses

1. One of my strengths stem from my ability of being a process driven designer where I try to logically answer questions throughout the process to move to the next step. This allows me to identify loop holes in services and systems and improve on ways to deliver a solution. For example while working with grant thornton, even though I was given a deifned deliverable since the beginning I was able to better refine the quality of them by understanding the requirments of the primary stakeholders from the deliverables which not done before.

2. This leads to cullminates into my second strength of identifying impactful opportunity areas to solve a problem.

3. Lastly, I believe I do have certain leadership qualities while working in groups that allow me to allocate and manage work that needs to be done in a pragmatic manner.

Weaknesses -

1. But this has also led to a discovery where I might seem a little bossy and pushy at time. With design being very subjective according to everyones individual opinion, I end up being puhsy of my opinions leading to microminaging the projects.

2. Lastly, I struggle with time management and allocation of the right amount of time to the different stages in a design process. Especially when it comes to knowing when to end the research stage and begin ideating on the deliverables. For example while working on a project around understanding accessibility barriers to STI infrastructures for female sex workers in Bhopal, we led to some key opportuniy areas but because of the time crunch we failed to develop a conrete solution.

Q2. What is your greatest achievement/major accomplishment?

Q3. What is your biggest failure or challenge? And learning from failure?

Achievement -

1. The greatest achievement of mine came extremely unexpectedly to me with me being awarded as the gold medalist of my batch in college. While I understand marks are very subjective and that this might not be the greatest achievement for many, It was for me because it helped me in my personal growth a lot. With NID being an extremely competitive college I was constantly in a position of self doubt, this affected my ability to communicate my ideas which is primary for a designer. But this achievement overturned these doubts and gave me a sense of confidence which I was earlier lacking making me believe a lot more on my abilities.

Failure -

1. During my second year of college, I set a goal to join a prestigious service-oriented organization I deeply admired. After successfully clearing the competitive portfolio round, I advanced to the final stage: the personal interview. I had thoroughly prepared, reviewing my portfolio, practicing responses, and researching the organization. However, during the interview, I became overwhelmed by the pressure I had placed on myself. Despite knowing the answers, I faltered, blanked out, and struggled to articulate my thoughts, ultimately failing to secure the position. While this was a disappointment, it taught me an invaluable lesson about managing pressure and maintaining composure. I realized that over-preparing to the point of overwhelm can hinder performance. Since then, I've adopted techniques such as mindfulness and positive visualization to remain calm under pressure. This experience has shaped my ability to perform better in high-stakes situations, turning a setback into a critical step toward personal growth.

Q4. Discuss a situation when you were a leader and describe your leadership style?

In my current organization where I work as a UI/UX designer I had the opportunity to lead a team of interns for a project for the first time in a professional setting. Considering this wasn't the first time I had to undertake leadership responsibilities in a team project because of my past academic experience and being mentored by other leaders, my qualities have evolved into being a leader who doesn't micro manage and lets designers take independent decisions while being accommodative of every team member's opinion. Considering design can be very subjective it is important to respect opinions and at the same time as a leader keep in mind what the client is looking for from the output. This comes from a combination of positive reinforcement and constructive criticism instead of only pointing out the "flaws" in a design.

Q5. Describe a situation where you have worked well in a team. and how do you manage conflict in a team?

Q6. How do you deal with criticism?

I believe, In design, criticism is an integral part of the process as it is highly subjective. Everyone from clients to the design leads have a different perspective on what makes a design "good" or effective and hence, criticism is a window into their vision from the design and priorities.

When I receive feedback, my first step is to listen carefully and seek to understand the underlying goals or concerns. Often, it's not just about the specific critique but about what they're trying to achieve through the design. I make it a point to ask clarifying questions to ensure I fully grasp their expectations.

For example, in a project I worked on during college, I jumped to an output fairly quickly based on my initial research and ideas. However, my mentor advised me to engage with more stakeholders in the ecosystem to gain a broader perspective and ensure the design was more informed and aligned with real needs. Taking that feedback, I revisited the research phase, spoke to additional stakeholders, and ended up with a far more effective and well-rounded design.

Tips

Many of these questions are covered in the submitted essays; please go through the essays and stay consistent

For weaknesses, it is a good idea to discuss with your recommenders

Each quality/skill/strength/weakness needs to be backed with an anecdote/real life incident

Do not exceed 180 seconds in any answer

GOALS AND COLLEGE SELECTION: As seen in the essays that we have strategized, your goals have to be in line with the college's offerings. Colleges will ask you probing questions on these

Q1. What are your short-term and long-term goals?

Short term goal -

The short term goal is to work as a user experience design or an Innovation strategist where I am able to actually gauge what the users wants are from services that are being offered to them via companies like IDEA or deloitte digital.

Long term goal -

India is a country with great amounts of human capital which I Personally feel hasn't been utilized fairly well. I believe that service design from a point of view of understanding customer and user requirement lacks with the right use of these human capitals. The larger goal is to work with business and help them achieve their larger goals by understanding touch points and eventually customer satisfaction. The goal is to improve the quality of growth of businesses. One example of such a scenario that I noticed was during my time at Grant Thornton Bharat, where they have a defined goal but are unable to reach it. Despite efforts to compete with established firms by hiring experienced employees, the organization struggles with imbalanced workloads and undefined workflows, impacting employee and client experiences. Its CSR initiatives, crucial for brand positioning, suffer due to a lack of proper frameworks.

Q2. Why do you want to join this College/University and why this degree (MBA/MS/BBA)?

Three reasons for me to join UALs service design course is honestly three fold if I had to divide it. First off, what caught my eye was the philosophy of design, which aims to teach futuristic design solutions, solutions to problems that might occur in the future, and how we as designers can speculate and be ready with the solutions for them. Especially with technology evolving at breakneck speed, it's important to consider how it can be maximized. This is reflected in the courses as well which interested me like the design futures. Secondly,

apart from the design futures course, the collaborative unit, which emphasizes working across disciplines had me intrigued because of my constant eagerness to work with various disciplines under design and learn as much as I could from other disciplines because I do strongly believe that a design solution doesn't exist in isolation; it is multiple disciplines coming together to invent a solution. Additionally, the idea of working on live projects directly from the industry bridges the gap of ambition and practicality which I struggled with during my phase of going from college to working in the industry and this is a huge opportunity for me to learn. Lastly, the resources that are offered by the college in itself. One which caught my attention was the Service Futures Lab, which focuses on extremely community-driven and societal issues which are sensitive and challenge to deal with. The lab's projects align with a lot of work that I have done in the past trying to work with underserved communities. There was one project that particularly stood out for me which was the creation of a climate studio. This example spoke to me because it dealt with a challenge and seeking solutions for it right at the societal level, it started small with a hope for a larger impact. It also combined so many varied disciplines of designers, murals, fashion inclined students etc where everyone was working to tackle with particular solution.

Q3. Why now?

As a recent graduate I believe my ability to learn and acquire new skills is still active and I would be better able to grasp things. Additionally, masters was always on my list to be able to acquire myself of better skills but a brief period of working in the industry has allowed me to refine my vocational skills of time management and reality check on project quality expectations. At the same time this period has allowed me to research and understand various courses better and understand where my interests for a masters programme lie.

Q4. Why do you think you would enjoy your chosen area of study (Eg: Marketing)?

Service design as a course is a lot more practical in my personal opinion and a very logical approach to design. It looks at design very holistically evaluating and understanding the logic behind why a problem exists and how it should be resolved in the most impactful manner. It aligns a lot with my personal design principle and I believe it has the power to make real changes to a problem area.

Additionally, considering I love working on projects where what the end output is remained undefined until the entire research has been conducted. The medium through which the solution is delivered can be extremely multi-disciplinary in nature making it exciting.

Adding onto this, I have had varied interests and knack for learning various design skills since the beginning, that's the main reason behind me choosing Industrial design, where I could learn research, tangible design as well as digital design which is very similar to what service design offers.

Q5. What are your expectations from this program?

- I expect to have the methodologies in place to tackle business and societal issues the same as knowing the appropriate research technique and how to approach a problem area
- At the same time, learn to be practical about project deliverables and what is a real-world solution for a problem
- Learn from various disciplines and various departments multiple skills on my journey

Q6. What are your backup goals?

Tips

Many of these questions are covered in the submitted essays; please go through the essays and stay consistent

Be very specific in goals; Do not beat around the bush

Please research the program thoroughly

Talk to Alumni/Current students

Do not exceed 120 seconds in any answer

MISCELLANEOUS & TECHNICAL QUESTIONS: Admissions officer are free to ask any question they say fit to understand your thought profile and technical skills better.

Q1. Who is your role model/ Who inspires you?

Q2. What is the difference between a good manager and a good leader? (Applicable for Management degrees)

Q3. Analytical: How many cars are there in your city now?

Q4. Describe an incident where you had to deal with diversity, equity, and inclusion.

Tips

Stay true to your profile. If you have an opinion on any topic please express it clearly. Do not be a fence sitter

For technical/role specific questions, it is absolutely fine to say "I don't know as my work/education has not covered this in depth"

If you have time between your interview call and the interview date, please brush up on current affairs, especially related to your field

Research online for different analytical questions asked for admissions to university for your degree.

Do not exceed 120 seconds in any answer

QUESTIONS TO ASK THE COLLEGE: Generally, at the end of interview, you will be asked if you have any questions for the university representative/ admissions office. You should have at least 2-3 specific questions prepared before any interview.

Some Standard Questions & Rationale

Can ask a question based on something you read in a brochure or on the school website regarding some co-curricular/ extra-curricular club that you are interested in

You can ask the interviewer why he or she decided to become part of the respective school.

Can Ask the interviewer about the school or program's greatest asset.

Can Ask the interviewer what advice he or she would offer: Any online / certificate courses he or she would recommend to develop your profile better to hand the rigors of the degree

Considering you are a service designer by profession, what courses would you recommend? Or some additional study material that can help us prep for before the course

What is the process of enrolling for these societies and what are the type of societies that can be found in college?

Please provide a personal statement that responds to the following questions as a part of your scholarship application (maximum of 2,000 characters (**approx. 350 words**) response per question)

1. Describe how receiving a Postgraduate Scholarship would make a difference to you

Receiving a Postgraduate Scholarship would be a transformative opportunity for me, allowing me to fully focus on my studies and professional aspirations without the financial burden that often comes with higher education. This scholarship would ease the financial strain of tuition fees and living expenses, reducing the need for part-time work and allowing me to dedicate more time to academic research and professional development. Beyond my education, this scholarship would enable me to contribute meaningfully to society. My goal is to work with various user groups throughout my journey and work on projects that impact healthcare access, developing sustainable solutions, and advancing technology. This financial support would bring me one step closer to making that vision a reality. I am deeply passionate about [your field], and this scholarship would not only ease financial constraints but also empower me to make a meaningful impact. I am truly grateful for the opportunity to be considered and excited about the possibilities this support could unlock.

2. Tell us how you intend to use the qualification you will be gaining to support your future plans *

A course in service design will allow me to see projects a lot more holistically and assess project outcomes more practically rather than being overambitious about it. A course in service design will allow me to understand how to blend strategy, technology, and design in a manner that makes an impact on a business. Specifically, I aim to work on service ecosystems that address pressing socio-economic inequities by co-creating accessible services for marginalized communities - such as affordable healthcare frameworks or skill-building digital platforms for rural artisans, inspired by my earlier work in Assam. I am also open to working on digital products like fintech solutions, or interactive educational platforms. My long-term vision is to become an expert in human-centric design by creating versatile design solutions that have high utility, speak to the audience, and help achieve the underlying business objectives.

3. Describe your background and your academic experience *

My Bachelor's degree from India's premier design school, National Institute of Design (NID), has given my design thought, creativity, and critical thinking a decisively humane and people-oriented direction. It introduced me to three facets of design: systems design, service design, and interaction design – each with its unique applications that called for deeper exploration. The systems approach calls for looking at a problem area holistically before identifying an intervention type, service design relies on solving design problems with the aid of techno-digital interventions, whereas interaction design sheds light on making such designs more user-centric.

Throughout my academic journey, I have maintained a consistently rising scorecard and earned the Highest Scorer award in my graduating cohort. But while my GPA of 8.6 in my Bachelor's in Industrial Design provides a glimpse into my academic progress, I believe the essence of design goes beyond conventional grading metrics and is demonstrated through practical application and impact.

As I took on design assignments in college, I increasingly saw that it also had the unique power to effect social change. What reinforced this was my on-site graduation project in collaboration with Grant Thornton, where I worked with indigenous bamboo artisans from Assam to revive endangered Japi crafts. Immersing myself in the local culture deepened my understanding of community-driven design and the impact it can have on the artisan as well as a customer. In another project, I redesigned construction barricades to improve safety for pedestrians during peak traffic hours. I used behavioral mapping to understand challenges around their installation, inconveniences faced by Rickshaw and Two-Wheeler drivers navigating around them, or

pedestrians crossing near construction zones. After a few rounds of on-ground testing of the full-scale prototype, I succeeded in designing a lightweight, highly visible barricade that was easy to install, maintain, and store.

From developing a mechanical tool for garland weaving that improved the efficiency and comfort of flower vendors to creating an educational activity kit exploring self-identity for children (the latter is selected for presentation and publication at the International Conference on Research into Design - ICoRD'25), all my projects have reiterated the interconnection of design, community, and sustainability.

From a bird's eye perspective, all my projects have reiterated the interconnection of design, utility, and sustainability. This understanding has been further strengthened through my professional experiences - at Thinkonomers (HDL), where I learned about the importance of user feedback in the design process; Pichkaari Design Studio, where I worked on rebranding projects and developed user flow enhancement prototypes; Grant Thornton; and finally, in my current role as a UX/UI designer at BRND Studio, where I handle end-to-end design for SaaS dashboards, educational platforms, and teaching tools. These experiences have ingrained in me that user experience should be the top priority in the design process and helped shape my own design philosophy, which is based on creating superlative, easy-to-use experiences for modern spaces, both virtual and real. For example, in my initial projects, I dove headfirst into design, but with experience and trial and error, I realized that logic in design will hold little value unless it is thoughtfully integrated with an intuitive understanding of how it will be used by humans.

4. Describe how you would use the qualification to address challenges faced by society in your home country, upholding the values of social justice and environmental stewardship *

Service design has the potential to transform how services are delivered and experienced in India, making them more inclusive, efficient, and sustainable. Growing up in a country with immense human capital, I have often observed that while there is no shortage of hard work, the lack of structured and intuitive systems often prevents that effort from translating into real impact. Whether in businesses, public services, or community-driven initiatives, the challenge isn't just about working harder—it's about working smarter.

One of the areas where this imbalance is most visible is in traditional craftsmanship and small-scale industries. Many artisans and local producers possess incredible skills, but without well-designed systems to connect them to the right markets, their work often goes unrecognized or undervalued. Service design can help create ecosystems that bridge this gap—by streamlining supply chains, improving access to technology, and ensuring that these businesses operate sustainably while still preserving cultural heritage. I saw this firsthand while working with artisans, where simply restructuring the way their products were positioned and marketed made a tangible difference in their livelihoods.

Beyond small businesses, service design has the power to improve workplace experiences at a larger scale. In many growing organizations, I have noticed how uneven workload distribution and inefficient workflows can lead to burnout, disengagement, and reduced productivity. Instead of adopting rigid structures modeled after international firms, businesses in India need solutions that are tailored to their unique challenges. Service design offers a way to rethink these systems—balancing workloads, redefining roles, and ensuring that employees and customers alike benefit from a more thoughtful and intuitive approach.

Public services, too, stand to benefit immensely from service design. Long queues at hospitals, complex government procedures, and inaccessible infrastructure are daily struggles for many people. Simple yet effective redesigns of these systems—whether through digital interventions, process restructuring, or better information accessibility—can make these essential services more humane and user-friendly.

Equally important is the role of service design in promoting environmental sustainability. India's rapid economic growth has often come at the expense of ecological well-being. By embedding sustainable practices into everyday services—whether in waste management, urban planning, or responsible consumption—service design can ensure that progress does not come at the cost of the planet.

Ultimately, service design is about creating experiences that work seamlessly for people, whether in business, governance, or daily life. India's potential is vast, and by prioritizing thoughtful, human-centered solutions, we can build systems that not only function efficiently but also uphold values of social justice, dignity, and sustainability.

5. Confirm any other sources of funding you have, or have applied for, to meet the cost of your studies in the UK. *

I will be taking a student loan for my entire master's education. I haven't applied for anything yet but eventually will be. Not sure what more to add here?

University of Washington - Personal Statement 01

How have your prior activities and experiences (e.g., things you have done at school, in the workplace, in your community, and/or extracurricular activities) prepared you for this program and this field? Please provide specific examples. [600 words maximum]

Growing up in Bangalore, life unfolded in straight lines and stark edges, where every structure was a servant of purpose, and aesthetics took a backseat to utility. It wasn't until I wandered through the vibrant streets of Barcelona during a trip in high school that I discovered the quiet poetry of aesthetics in public spaces. This revelation stirred a deep admiration within me during those early years. My ensuing creative practice has been shaped by my undergraduate studies in Industrial Design and diverse professional experiences, deepening my understanding of how design can bridge the gap between function and form, utility and beauty.

I pursued my Bachelor's degree from India's premier design school, the National Institute of Design (NID), where my design thinking and creativity took a decisively humane and people-oriented direction. During my time at NID, I was introduced to three facets of design: systems design, service design, and interaction design. These areas provided me with a holistic perspective on design and offered deep insights into how we can tackle problems creatively, using diverse approaches. The systems approach taught me to look at a problem area in its entirety before identifying potential interventions, while service design focused on solving problems through technological interventions. Interaction design highlighted the importance of user-centricity, making designs intuitive and accessible.

In college, I took on multiple design assignments that highlighted the power of design in making a tangible impact on society. One such project was my graduation assignment with Grant Thornton, where I worked with indigenous bamboo artisans from Assam to revive endangered Japi crafts. Immersing myself in the local culture gave me a deeper understanding of community-driven design, and I saw firsthand how design could benefit both artisans and customers. Additionally, in another project, I redesigned construction barricades to improve safety for pedestrians during peak traffic hours. Using behavioral mapping to understand the challenges faced by pedestrians and drivers, I designed a lightweight, highly visible barricade that was easy to install, maintain, and store after a few rounds of on-ground testing.

Another project involved designing a mechanical tool to improve the efficiency and comfort of garland weaving for flower vendors in my hometown Bengaluru. The manual weaving process caused repetitive strain injuries for many vendors. By using a participatory design approach, I co-created a tool that alleviated the physical strain and increased the productivity of the weavers. This experience further strengthened my belief in design as a catalyst for positive change.

Beyond these community-based projects, I worked on tech-intensive projects as well. For instance, I analyzed STI management practices and barriers restricting access to services among female sex workers (FSWs) in Bhopal. I employed snowball sampling techniques to locate their work zones and, using methods like GIGA mapping user journeys, developed a Trigger and Response Model to better interpret the data. The project led to recommendations for community-centric support systems such as mobile clinics and awareness programs. Another project involved creating an educational activity kit to help children explore self-identity. By utilizing user journey mapping, participatory testing, and iterative prototyping, I built a tool to help children understand and express their feelings, which was later presented and published at the International Conference on Research into Design (ICoRD'25).

All these experiences have shaped my design philosophy, which now prioritizes user experience in every project. At Thinkonomers (HDL), Pichkaari Design Studio, and my current role as a UX/UI designer at BRND

Studio, I have learned to embrace user feedback as a crucial part of the design process. These roles taught me the importance of integrating logic and user understanding, which have refined my ability to deliver practical solutions that resonate with real users. Whether working on SaaS dashboards or educational platforms, I now approach every project with a balance of creativity, usability, and empathy.

University of Washington - Personal Statement 02

Please describe your particular interest in Human Centered Design & Engineering, and explain what specific elements of the program make it a good fit for you. How will this program assist you in your longer-term goals? Please provide specific examples. [600 words maximum]

From a bird's eye perspective, all my projects have reiterated the interconnection of design, utility, and sustainability. These principles have inspired my interest in pursuing Human Centered Design & Engineering (HCDE), where I hope to deepen my expertise and apply my skills in designing for real-world challenges. The driving force behind my desire to study HCDE is my interest in blending design, technology, and social impact—areas that align perfectly with my long-term career goals.

After completing my graduate studies, I aim to work as a User Experience (UX) Researcher or Innovation Strategist with creative firms such as Accenture, Anthro-Tech, Inc., or IDEO. I am passionate about working on service ecosystems that address pressing socio-economic inequities. For example, I am interested in designing accessible services for marginalized communities, such as affordable healthcare frameworks or digital platforms for skill-building among rural artisans. These goals are inspired by my earlier project in Assam, where I worked with artisans to develop community-driven solutions. Additionally, I am open to contributing to digital products like fintech solutions or interactive educational platforms, using my design background to create user-friendly, impactful tools.

The Human Centered Design & Engineering program at the University of Washington offers the ideal environment for me to cultivate my skills and achieve these goals. I am particularly drawn to the Accessibility and Inclusive Design and Usability Studies modules, which emphasize design thinking and the practical application of industry-relevant tools. The program's emphasis on practical learning through industry collaborations, live projects, and its state-of-the-art MakeLab, The Momentary Experience Lab, and Inclusive Design Lab excites me as they provide an opportunity to experiment with emerging technologies such as high-end VR systems and 3D printers.

Moreover, the University of Washington's collaborative atmosphere, which includes industry events and Capstone Showcases, will provide me with valuable opportunities to engage with like-minded peers and professionals. By working on team-based innovations, I will be able to contribute to contemporary social and environmental challenges, while gaining hands-on experience in developing solutions. I am excited to make the most of these opportunities, knowing that they will shape me into an industry-ready professional, equipped with the skills necessary to achieve my long-term goals.

In sum, the HCDE program will allow me to deepen my understanding of design principles while enabling me to apply them to create accessible, impactful solutions. By joining this program, I will be positioned to make a meaningful contribution to the field of human-centered design and engineering, helping to shape the future of design for social good.

Hi, I'm Rachit Singhi. An industrial designer who is extremely passionate about creating impactful and thoughtful design experiences and solutions.

Growing up in Bangalore, I was surrounded by residential and corporate complexes with more focus on utility than aesthetics. It wasn't until I visited Barcelona, for my high school trip, that I discovered the quiet poetry of aesthetics even in public places. As I undertook design assignments in college, I discovered that it also had the power to effect social change—whether it's creating tools for the underserved communities or designing products to improve everyday experiences. One project that deeply shaped my perspective was my work with the indigenous bamboo artisans from Assam to revive the Japi craft. This experience truly reinforced my belief that design doesn't just change environments. However, this process requires deep research and analysis of the user's ecosystem, and careful attention to where the most impactful change can happen.

This has seeded my design philosophy that interaction design is not just about functionality and aesthetics—it's about weaving together empathy, creativity, and systemic thinking into my design solutions. I believe good design should empower users and cater to larger societal needs. With design and technology evolving at breakneck speed, ensuring accessibility to diverse populations is more important than ever. I'm thus excited to bring my passion for user-centered solutions and my drive for interdisciplinary innovation to the next chapter of my journey—and I cannot wait to share that with you at SVA!

Receiving a postgraduate scholarship would be a transformative opportunity, allowing me to fully focus on my studies and professional aspirations without the financial burden that often accompanies higher education. This scholarship would ease the strain of tuition fees and living expenses, reducing the need for part-time work and enabling me to dedicate more time to academic research and professional development. The necessity of securing a part-time job to meet financial requirements would otherwise divert my attention and impact the quality of my academic output.

The University of the Arts London (UAL) offers an exceptional environment for innovation, with industry collaborations, live projects, and state-of-the-art facilities like the Service Futures Lab, Creative Technology Lab, and Digital Space. These resources provide the perfect foundation for exploring emerging technologies such as VR and projection mapping. UAL's emphasis on real-world projects would allow me to work on industry-standard assignments while excelling academically, a commitment I am eager to fully embrace.

Beyond the structured curriculum, I am eager to engage in interdisciplinary learning and collaborate across different fields. Exploring various disciplines, participating in student unions and societies, and collaborating with intellectually spirited peers in initiatives like the UAL Creative Hackathon would enrich my academic journey. Engaging in team-based innovation to devise solutions for contemporary social and environmental challenges is a prospect that excites me. With the freedom to immerse myself in these opportunities, I am confident I will graduate as an industry-ready professional with the skills and knowledge to achieve my goals without unnecessary distractions.

Beyond my education, this scholarship would empower me to contribute meaningfully to society. I aspire to work with diverse user groups and develop impactful projects in areas such as healthcare access, sustainable solutions, and technological advancements. The financial support provided by this scholarship would bring me one step closer to making that vision a reality.

I am deeply passionate about Service Design, and this scholarship would alleviate financial stress, allowing me to focus on creating meaningful impact. I am truly grateful for the opportunity to be considered and excited about the possibilities this support could unlock.

Social Action Impact Award in Human Centered Design & Engineering -

The Social Action Impact Award supports students with a demonstrated commitment to diversity, equity, and inclusion. It is the Donor's hope that this Fund will inspire students to engage with their communities and/or in equity-related work to advance systems and technologies that create accessible, sustainable, and prosperous futures. Applicants should write a personal statement (500 words max.) describing their contributions as they relate to these areas.

I'm Rachit Singhi, an industrial designer passionate about creating thoughtful, impactful design experiences and solutions. As I worked on co-curricular design assignments during undergraduate studies, I discovered that apart from utility and aesthetics, design also had the power to effect social change. One project that truly reinforced this was my on-site research with Grant Thornton, where I worked with indigenous bamboo artisans from Assam to revive the endangered Japi craft. It showed me how designers can breathe new life into products and services, creating self-sustaining and equitable solutions for marginalised stakeholders.

This, and many more such experiences, have laid my foundation for a broader design practice rooted in empathy. Since then, my work has engaged a wide range of diverse communities — from working with transgender and STI patients to children with disabilities and senior citizens — each project has aimed at reiterating the interconnection of design with diversity, equity, and inclusion. From designing a tool to ease physical strain and improve productivity for traditional garland weavers to using behavioural mapping to create safer, more visible construction barricades, I have understood how participatory design can directly enhance dignity, productivity, and livelihood for underserved communities whose challenges are often not easily visible.

Additionally, I have worked on research-intensive projects too, helping me analyse and create impactful design suggestions from a systemic point of view. By studying the barriers to STI healthcare access among female sex workers in Bhopal, the studies could unveil recommendations on community-centric support systems, inclusive infrastructure, and accessible awareness programmes. In another, I designed an educational activity kit to help children understand and respond to inappropriate touch, later presented at the International Conference on Research into Design (ICoRD'25).

My myriad set of formative learnings has coalesced into my passion for making a career in human-centred design and user experience research. I have come to appreciate that product design, albeit a creative process, requires conversance with software design tools, user-centric methodologies, and an allied understanding of socio-economic dynamics and business management to truly understand and deliver the consumer's ask. Inspired by my prior work in Assam, I hope to create frameworks like skill-building and business training digital platforms for tribal artists or reasonably priced and accessible healthcare models for communities like female sex workers.

Through several projects, I have understood that design has a unique ability to identify problems, craft solutions, and create smooth, user-centred experiences. The programme's scope of experiential learning through industry collaborations, live projects, and its state-of-the-art Value Sensitive Design Lab and the DO-IT Centre excites me, as they provide an opportunity to work on people-oriented projects. This scholarship will empower me to focus fully on developing scalable, inclusive

technologies that serve those too often overlooked. With my foundation in socially engaged design and my drive to address systemic inequities, I am committed to becoming a leader who uses design not just to solve problems — but to reshape systems by creating high-utility, user-oriented solutions fit for both corporate goals and society's demands.

1. As the only and first alumni member of the Board of Studies at the National Institute of Design - Industrial Design, I have been contributing to critical curriculum revision discussions that aim to align academic programs with industry standards and future trends. In this capacity, I work collaboratively with faculty members, administrators, and other industry experts, providing insights drawn from professional experience and advocating for updates that would enhance student learning outcomes. This role requires active listening, clear communication, thoughtful problem solving, and the ability to provide constructive feedback in formal settings. My participation helps support continuous improvement efforts and reflects a commitment to quality, professionalism, and service — qualities that are equally important in customer-facing and team-oriented roles where one must uphold standards, contribute to shared goals, and ensure smooth operations. Additionally, as the recipient of the Academic Excellence Award during my undergraduate studies, I have demonstrated consistency and dedication to high performance, qualities that I continue to uphold in my professional and academic contributions. As an alumni member of the KAPILA Committee under the Kalam Program for IP Literacy and Awareness, I aim to contribute meaningfully to building a robust intellectual property (IP) ecosystem within the institution. With my background in design and industry exposure, I bring a nuanced understanding of innovation, technology translation, and user-centered solutions, which aligns with KAPILA's goal of fostering IP awareness and increasing the number of quality patent filings from higher education institutions. My role involves evaluating patent applications for their originality, commercial viability, and alignment with national relevance, while also mentoring students and faculty on best practices in protecting and leveraging their innovations. I see this as a critical step in strengthening a culture of research-backed creativity and systematic IP protection within the academic environment.